A third-cumulant chain at its boundary: consistency, random projections, the price of carrying κ_3, and where the next order's accuracy lives

ARC White-Box Estimation Challenge 2026 — Phase 2 — Algorithmic Contribution write-up. Participant: ***Artyom Kuznetsov*** *(AIcrowd* `Artyom_Mazur`*). Designated submission:* ***333534****, graded* ***3.7357e-9*** *(final-layer MSE 2.0317e-8 at 18.33% of the FLOP budget; 0 failures on all 100 grader networks). Claim labels:* ***[M]*** *measured in a logged run ·* ***[D]*** *derived algebraically ·* ***[U]*** *our interpretation, not isolated by an intervention. The use of language models in this work is described in §9.*

Summary

Task and result. Predict the per-neuron mean post-ReLU activation of every layer of a random He-initialised ReLU network (width 1024, depth 16, Gaussian input) within 2^{41} analytical FLOPs; the score is the final-layer MSE times max(0.1, FLOPs/budget). Our estimator is a cumulant-propagation chain closed at the third cumulant. Its skeleton is the SIMPLE k = 3 algorithm of Wu et al. (arXiv:2605.05179) and their MIT reference implementation, re-derived and re-implemented from scratch (§3.1); everything else in §3 is ours unless a credit says otherwise. The designated submission scores 3.7357e-9: ×108 better than covariance propagation, ×2.1 more accurate than the reference algorithm at ×8 less compute. It is the last of ten consecutive versions that each landed within 0.3% of their pre-submission projection (§5.1).

What we would like judged. Six measured statements about why this family of estimators behaves as it does. Each is stated as a rule with the prediction it makes, and each is backed by an oracle-substitution or a metered measurement rather than by an argument.

1. **The next layer's per-neuron errors are random projections of this layer's joint errors** (§6.4, Proposition 1). ΔC(l), the error of the chain's post-activation covariance, is independent of W(l+1), so the variance error of neuron i is $w_i^T \Delta C\, w_i$: a coherent level from tr ΔC plus independent noise across neurons set by the off-diagonal part. Verified against 10^7-sample covariance oracles (predicted/measured 0.89–1.09; 95% of the energy is off-diagonal). The κ_3 error is an odd-order projection and has no coherent level at all (Proposition 2; $z^2 = 0.93$ over 28 layer–network pairs), and the real columns' errors are spread exactly like the chain's errors along random directions independent of the network (spread ratios 0.96–1.12 and equal means over four layers of two networks). This is why every corrector of a neuron's moments from its own state failed on our chain: the part of the error such a model can see is worth ×1.0; the part it cannot is worth ×0.3. What a per-neuron correction can learn is set by the truncation order, not by depth: about two thirds of a Gaussian closure's error at every shape from 256 × 8 to 1024 × 16, ≤ 4% of a k = 3 chain's, because a neuron's true κ_3 is proportional to its own mean: the slope at every layer is the projection of the post-activation partial trace on the mean (exact in expectation, confirmed to ~1%), its first value is derived ($c(1) \cdot n = 13.91$, measured 13.94), and carried inside a Gaussian closure the law removes exactly the learnable part (§6.4). `scripts/error_anatomy.py` measures this for any estimator from its outputs.
2. **The third cumulant is not closed on the two slices the nonlinear step reads** (§6.2). The all-distinct part of κ_3 is 28.8% of the next layer's diagonal per layer, orthogonal to everything computable in $O(n^2)$, and ×25.6 end to end without it. κ_4 can be closed in $O(n^2)$ because it enters

the readout at second order; κ_3 is the readout. The 28.8% is derived, not only measured (Proposition 3: share² = $6\|G_{AD}\|^2 / (6\|G\|^2 + 9\|v\|^2)$, measured/predicted 1.00 ± 0.06 at n = 256), and it falls only slowly with width. Independently replicated by team 504aldo (forum 18218) with different code and a different instrument.

3. **The construction costs what it saves** (§6.1). Five compressions of the κ_3 state, each affordable by a cost model that priced the saved product, each dead on the meter when the construction of the compressed object was priced: the basis, the fit, the rotation, the entry. The one compression that ships (§3.6) is the one whose basis is never rebuilt. The rule predicts the fate of compressions we never tried.
4. **Consistency: the chain's errors compensate, so remove a term on both sides or not at all** (§3.5, §2c). Three changes that removed computation and gained accuracy (matched dead-neuron cuts, saturated rows of D with the κ_4 level they carried restored, one Edgeworth coefficient dropped in all three pair channels); and the mirror image from the oracle side: exact variance alone can make the result worse (×1.09), exact variance, κ_3 and κ_4 together give ×0.12.
5. **One order up: the missing accuracy is the young fourth cumulant, and we can say which trees** (§7). At small width ARC's k = 4 is ×3–7 better than our chain; its gain lives in the κ_4 born in the last two layers, above all in the graph that hands the whole third cumulant on through one covariance edge (the "3+2" tree; without it the young κ_4 is worse than none). Inside ARC's own k = 4, three layers of κ_4 blocks plus one scale-mixture block for the rest keep 89% of its gain over k = 3 at 256 × 16 for 0.4 of the κ_4 columns (§7.3). A reader of those trees built from our chain's own state cuts our raw error to ×0.70 on all ten full-width test networks, close to the leaders' raw error; metered in our representation, it costs about what it buys (×0.97 in score at best), so it is not in the designated submission. The one variant we did port, to measure it on the grader, is ×0.92 raw on the hundred public networks at +5% FLOPs, and the grader zeroed 16 of them for residual time: the construction is priced in metered calls as well as in FLOPs (§7.4).
6. **The instrument has a resolution** (§6.5): a lever worth under 2–3% cannot be validated by a submission, and a scalar fitted on ten networks arrives at a third of its strength on a hundred. Structural levers transfer; the ten ports that landed on their projections are the evidence.

The method, briefly (§3; ablation on 32 fresh networks in §5.2). A κ_4 closure in $O(n^2)$ from the Gaussian scale mixture ($\kappa_{4_i} \propto \mathrm{var}_i^2$, $K22 \propto \mathrm{var}_i\mathrm{var}_j + 2C0_{i\,j}^2$), which pays only together with the edge × κ_3 diagram C0·D that the reference truncates (together ×1.136; each alone ≤ ×1.07 or harmful; on the final stack ×1.30 and ×1.17 when removed); the rest of the first-order scale-mixture set, including a $\kappa_4 \to \kappa_3$ feed; the augmented path births where they are cheap; the consistency cuts of item 4; old sources in a rank-448 basis that rides the transport (×0.893, 100/100 networks); one learned correction of the κ_4 diagonal from $O(n^2)$ row reductions of matrices the chain already holds (the idea is mliston's, forum 18170; ×0.988 out of sample and ×0.988 on the grader); and exact arithmetic — Strassen–Winograd as flopscope operations, symmetric and triangular savings — which we report in Appendix A because it is engineering.

What we did not achieve. The top of the board is ×1.5–1.8 more accurate and ×1.5–1.8 cheaper than this method, by means that are not published. Item 5 explains the accuracy; the cheaper base the leaders must have for the κ_3 state is the part we did not find, and §6.1–§6.2 say why none of the constructions we could price gives it. §8 lists what we would try next.

How this document was made. Every number comes from a logged run with a self-check (§1); the journal of the work, including seventy-six catalogued negative results with their mechanisms, is released with the code (§10). The participant directed the research and Claude Code wrote the code and the drafts under that direction; §9 states the division of labour and the errors the model made.

1. Setting, metric and harness

Task. Layer l computes $y^{(l)} = \mathrm{ReLU}(W^{(l)\top} y^{(l-1)})$ with $W^{(l)} \sim N(0, 2/n)$ i.i.d., width $n = 1024$, depth $L = 16$, and input $y^{(-1)} \sim N(0, I_n)$. The estimator returns $E[y^{(l)}]$ for every layer. The score is the final-layer MSE against an $N = 10^9$ Monte-Carlo ground truth, times `max(0.1, C/B)`, with `C` the FLOPs billed by flopscope and `B = 2^41`, averaged over networks. All arithmetic goes through `flopscope.numpy`; the grader zeroes a network's prediction if its non-flopscope ("residual") time exceeds 0.4 s, its wall time 120 s, or its memory 8 GB (Appendix A.2).

Notation. For a pre-activation `z` with mean μ and covariance C: $\sigma_i = \sqrt{C_{ii}}$, $\alpha_i = \mu_i/\sigma_i$, and under the Gaussian closure $d_1 = E[\mathrm{ReLU}'(z_i)] = \Phi(\alpha_i)$, $d_2 = E[\mathrm{ReLU}''(z_i)] = \phi(\alpha_i)/\sigma_i$. C0 is C with its diagonal removed; $t = \kappa_{3iii}$; $D = \kappa_{3ij\,j}$ (the (2,1) slice); $K22 = \kappa_{4ij\,j\,j}$. "Raw" means the final-layer MSE; "util" means C/B.

The baseline everyone starts from is covariance propagation ("k = 2": the linear step exact, a Gaussian closure at every ReLU): raw 4.05e-6 at 2.35% of the budget on the 100 public networks, i.e. adjusted 4.05e-7. Plain sampling at the same metric bottoms out near 1.2e-6. The method of §3 reaches raw 2.03e-8 at 18.3% of the budget (adjusted 3.74e-9) — 200× more accurate than covariance propagation.

Harness and discipline. Every number in this document is a logged measurement against the baked 10^9 ground truth of the public `mini` split (100 networks) unless it is labelled otherwise. Three instruments are used:

- the **production estimator** under the official runner (`whest run`), which gives exact FLOPs and the score;
- a **float64 research chain** in torch with every term as a switch, used for ablations and oracle substitutions (it reproduces ARC's reference implementation slice by slice to 1e-15, and the production estimator to ≤1e-6);
- **Monte-Carlo oracles** of the chain's intermediate state (per-neuron moments, the full post-activation covariance, the (2,1) slice) at 10^7 samples with two independent seeds, so that an oracle's own noise is measured and subtracted rather than assumed away.

Every switch, when off, reproduces its predecessor bitwise (production) or to float rounding (research chain); every new measurement harness is first gated on a number it must reproduce. Those gates caught, among others, a double-applied ReLU gate, a wrong layer's weight matrix in a delegated analysis (a bogus 138% effect), unstandardised regression features, and a float64 overflow at dead neurons — each before it could become a claim. We use **[M]** for a measured claim, **[D]** for one derived algebraically or computed from measured numbers, and **[U]** for our interpretation where an intervention has not isolated it.

Two machines. Most measurements ran on one laptop; long batch jobs (oracles, catalogue screens) ran in Claude Code cloud sessions with the same pinned code. FLOP counts and MSEs agree between the two to the printed digit; wall and residual times do not transfer, so every timing decision was taken on the laptop and confirmed from the grader's own telemetry, which every submission page publishes.

2. Where the error lives

Every design decision in §3 and every closure in §6 was made against an **oracle-substitution** measurement: run the chain, and at chosen layers replace one quantity of its state by its Monte-Carlo

value (10^7 samples, two independent seeds so that the oracle's own noise can be measured and subtracted), then see what that is worth on the final layer. The measurements below are the ones the rest of the document leans on. All are upper bounds on what *any* method could gain through the substituted quantity, and we label them as such.

(a) The Gaussian-closure error is a mean error, and the parts of the state multiply [M]. Covariance propagation (the linear step exact, a Gaussian closure at every ReLU) has raw error 5.15e-6 on our first three networks. Injecting exact quantities into it, one at a time and together (Part I of this project, `state_split3`):

upstream mean	upstream covariance	Edgeworth readout	final-layer MSE	vs k = 2
chain's	chain's	no	5.15e-6	1×
exact	chain's	no	2.22e-7	23×
exact	chain's	yes	1.84e-7	28×
k = 3 chain's	k = 3 chain's	yes	6.41e-8	80×
exact	k = 3 chain's	yes	2.94e-8	**175×**

A perfect final readout alone is worth 1.08× on a bad state and 3.8× on a good one: no component can be judged in isolation, and the third cumulant's job is to get the *propagated means* right.

(b) The remaining error is born in the kink core of every layer, not in the tails [M]. On the current chain, substituting exact post-activation means for one activation regime at a time (ten networks; a cloud session): dead neurons ($\alpha = \mu/\sigma < -2.5$) ×0.995, saturated ×0.49, the kink ×0.21, all ×0.21; inside the kink, the core ($|\alpha| < 1$) ×0.34, the saturating shoulder ×0.52, the dead shoulder ×0.93. About four fifths of the final error travels through intermediate means and is born **where the ReLU is most nonlinear and the Edgeworth series most reliable**: fed exact moments, our first-order readout is accurate to ~1e-12 of the layer MSE in both tails and ~1e-10 in the kink. The tails, which the Phase-1 literature and our own first hypothesis blamed, hold none of it; a 149-arm screen of tail-term restrictions found nothing beyond §3.5's consistency fixes.

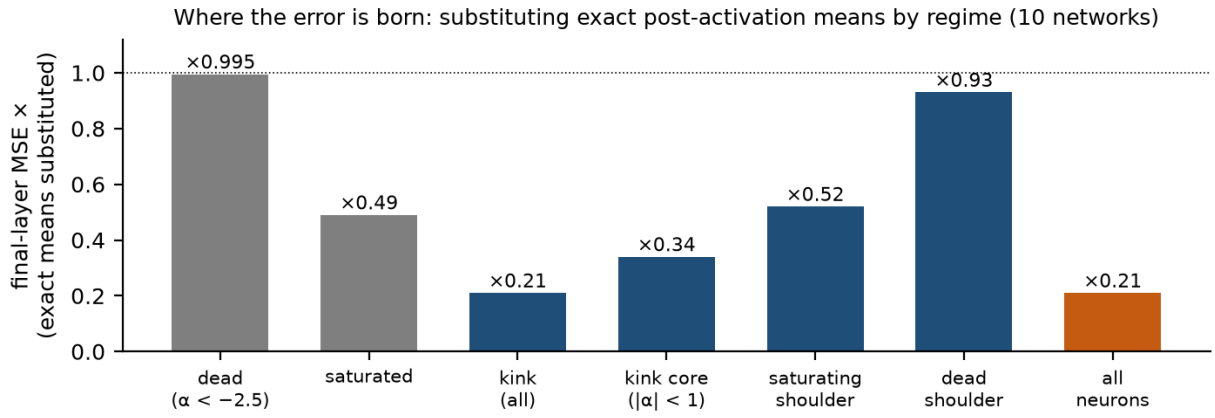


Figure 1. Oracle substitution of exact post-activation means, one activation regime at a time (ten networks, × of the chain's final-layer MSE). The dead regime holds nothing; the kink core, where the ReLU is most nonlinear, holds most of the error.

(c) The channels only work together [M]. Exact pre-activation moments of the kink neurons substituted at every layer: variance alone ×0.64 / ×0.82 (two networks), κ_4 alone ×0.78, κ_3 alone ×0.88 — and **all three at once ×0.12 / ×0.13**. Exact variance alone is even *harmful* on one network (×1.09 when substituted for all neurons). The chain's errors in its channels are mutually consistent, and a

correction of one channel breaks that consistency; this is the same phenomenon as §3.5 seen from the oracle side, and it is the reason §3.7's corrector touches one channel only.

(d) What the per-neuron errors are made of [M + D]. §6.4 proves and measures that the next layer's per-neuron variance error is, 95% of it, a random projection of the off-diagonal post-covariance error through the next layer's independent weights — the reason every learned per-neuron correction of the variance failed, and the reason the oracle reserve of (c), real as it is, is out of reach of anything cheap.

So the target is sharply posed: the error is in the per-neuron moments of kink-core neurons, it is jointly consistent across channels, and its rough part is a projection of joint-cumulant errors. §3 is what we could fix within that; §6 is why the rest resists.

3. The method

The estimator is a cumulant-propagation chain closed at the third cumulant. **Its skeleton is the SIMPLE k = 3 algorithm of Wu et al. (arXiv:2605.05179) and their MIT reference implementation** `mlp_cumulant_propagation`, which we re-derived from the paper and re-implemented from scratch for flopscope; §3.1 states exactly what we took. Everything after §3.1 is ours unless a credit says otherwise. Every component is a constructor switch, and switching it off reproduces its predecessor: bitwise in the production estimator, and to float rounding (≤ 1e-6) against the float64 research chain. Each subsection ends with the graded submission that first shipped it.

step	component (section)	100 public MLPs, local	graded (50 public of 100)	util
k3b	the reference chain in our source representation + workspace Strassen (3.1)	1.98e-8	1.915e-8 (331962)	55.9%
k3e	scale-mixture κ_4 closure + the C0·D diagram (3.2)	9.76e-9	9.562e-9 (332066)	32.3%
k3f	the rest of the first-order scale-mixture set (3.3)	8.59e-9	8.286e-9 (332128)	32.4%
k3h	Strassen level 4 through sum-of-products pairings (A.1)	7.67e-9	7.401e-9 (332142)	28.9%
k3i	the augmented term set where it is cheap (3.4)	6.92e-9	6.728e-9 (332170)	29.8%
k3j → k3m	dead rows out of every contraction (3.5)	5.52e-9	5.3906e-9 (332403)	24.8%
k3o	the matched dead-side row + column cut (3.5)	5.25e-9	5.1127e-9 (333028)	23.8%
k3p	old sources in a basis that rides the transport (3.6)	4.68e-9	4.5644e-9 (333029)	20.7%
k3q	saturated rows out of D, κ_4 level restored — E2 (3.5)	4.24e-9	4.1279e-9 (333276)	19.7%
k3r	marg2, the pair expansion's one k = 2 defect (3.5)	4.17e-9	4.0579e-9 (333307)	19.7%
k3t	Strassen level 5 on three contractions (A.1)	4.06e-9	3.9554e-9 (333357)	19.2%
k3v	the learned κ_4-diagonal corrector (3.7)	(87 fresh MLPs ×0.988)	3.9102e-9 (333368)	19.3%

step	component (section)	100 public MLPs, local	graded (50 public of 100)	util
k3w, k3x	level 5 on two more contractions (A.1)	3.90e-9	3.8069e-9 (333398)	18.7%
k3y	symmetric C_pre, explicit triangular R^{-1} (A.1)	3.85e-9	3.7573e-9 (333402)	18.4%
k3z	**Winograd's 15-addition form; level 5 inside the C_pre halves (A.1)**	**3.83e-9**	**3.7357e-9 (333534)**	**18.3%**

Algorithm 1 — one layer of the designated estimator, with the subsection of each line. State carried from layer l–1: the post-activation mean μ and covariance C; the young κ_3 sources s = (A_s, B_s, H_s, g_s); the old ones as coefficients Z_s in the band basis P; the post-activation κ_4 diagonal and (2,2) level.

```
1  μ ← Wᵀμ;  C_pre ← Wᵀ(CW);  var = diag C_pre;  C0 = C_pre − diag(var);
   α = μ/√var                                                        §3.1
2  dead neurons (α < −2.5) leave every contraction; the young legs and Pᵀ
   move one layer: Xᵀ ← (gated Xᵀ)·W                          §3.5, §3.6
3  the old sources' legs, materialised: (A, B) = P·(Z_A, Z_B)            §3.6
4  read κ₃: tᵢ = 3 Σ_s Σ_p g_p A_ip B_ip² + thin, feed and path terms;
   D = Σ_s (L1·Bᵀ + L2·Aᵀ) + …; rows of D with α > 2.5 removed and the κ₄
   level they carried restored by one matrix–vector product       §3.1, §3.5
5  close κ₄ in O(n²): level v from sum and trace identities;
   κ₄ᵢᵢᵢᵢ = 3v·varᵢ² (+ the newest source's star birth, + the learned
   correction at layers 8–14);  K22 = v(varᵢvarⱼ + 2C0ᵢⱼ²);
   K31 = 0.65·3v·varᵢC0ᵢⱼ                                    §3.2–§3.4, §3.7
6  the ReLU step: power moments with Edgeworth terms in (t, κ₄); pair
   power cumulants with the C0·D, K31, C0³, C0∘K22 diagrams and the marg2
   coefficients; Leonov–Shiryaev → post-activation μ (layer l's output)
   and C                                                          §3.1–§3.5
7  the source that reaches age 5 enters the band: Z = R⁻¹QᵀX, P = QR   §3.6
8  birth: hubs = neurons with α ≥ −2.5; B = diag(d₁)·C0 on those columns;
   g = d₂; correction leg = column rescaling of B + rank-24 thin leg;
   the path leg, read once at the next layer                      §3.1, §3.4
```

3.1 What we took from the reference, and the representation we put it in

Taken from Wu et al. (credit, not contribution). The linear step is exact: $\mu \leftarrow W^T\mu$, $C \leftarrow W^TCW$, and every factor of κ_3 is multiplied by W^T. At each ReLU, with $w(k,p) = E[\partial^k \mathrm{ReLU}(Z)^p]$ for $Z \sim N(\mu_i, \sigma_i^2)$: single-index power moments with Edgeworth terms, $P_p = w(0,p) + w(3,p)\cdot t/6 + w(4,p)\cdot\kappa_{4iiii}/24$ with $t = \kappa_{3iii}$; pair power cumulants $Q(p,q) = a_1b_1C0 + \tfrac{1}{2}a_1b_2D^T + \tfrac{1}{2}a_2b_1D + \tfrac{1}{2}a_2b_2C0^2 + \tfrac{1}{4}a_2b_2K22$ ($a_k = w(k,p)_i$, $b_k = w(k,q)_j$, C0 the covariance without its diagonal, $D = \kappa_{3ij\,j}$, $K22 = \kappa_{4ij\,j\,j}$), converted to cumulants by Leonov–Shiryaev; a third-cumulant birth at every layer (the tree diagram $\mathrm{Sym}(U \otimes 3I \otimes U\cdot\mathrm{diag}(d_2))$, $U = \mathrm{diag}(d_1)C0$, plus a correction block that makes the repeated- index slices exact); and a one-step Edgeworth readout of the post-ReLU mean. The reference keeps κ_4 as one radial scalar. It reaches raw MSE 4.25e-8 on our first three networks at 148% of the budget; our re-implementation reproduces every slice of it to 1e-15 [M].

Our representation: sources, and only the slices the step reads. Each birth at layer m creates a *source*: a hub leg A (the transport since birth; the identity at birth), a tree leg B = A·U, a correction leg, and a fixed hub weight $g = d_2$ at birth. The κ_3 tensor is never formed. The next step reads only its diagonal t and its (2,1) slice D, so only those are built:

```
t_i = 3 Σ_s Σ_p g_p A_ip B_ip² + (correction-leg terms),      D = Σ_s [L1·Bᵀ + L2·Aᵀ
+ (thin terms)],
L1 = 2 A∘B∘g,  L2 = B²∘g + …
```

After each step every leg row is gated by d_1. The correction leg splits **exactly** into a column rescaling of the tree leg, 3B·diag(α) with $\alpha = w(1,2) - 2P_1d_1$, which is free because it survives transport unchanged, and a remainder that is numerically low-rank, carried as a thin leg of rank 24 found by a seeded randomized range finder (×1.004 against the exact split; R dropped entirely costs ×10.5) [M]. Every per-source operation is one batched flopscope call per layer into preallocated buffers; that is what keeps the non-flopscope ("residual") time under the grader's 0.4 s cap.

3.2 A closure that makes the fourth cumulant free — and the diagram it needs

The fourth cumulant enters the readout and the pair cumulants. Transporting its (2,2) structure ("memo22": the direct pairings of $\mathrm{Wsq}^T(\mathrm{K22} + \mathrm{diag\ K4})\mathrm{Wsq}$, $\mathrm{Wsq} = W \circ W$) beats the reference's radial scalar (3.75e-8 against 4.25e-8, 3/3 networks) but costs two dense products per layer and gets the per-neuron **pattern** wrong (correlation with a Monte-Carlo oracle 0.23–0.53) [M]. Two findings replace it.

(a) The missing per-step diagram. Fed exact (Monte-Carlo) inputs, the SIMPLE step loses 2.3 / 3.5 / 4.5% of the post-ReLU (2,2) level at layers 6 / 10 / 14. The missing term is the cross term of the joint Edgeworth exponent between the edge C0 and the κ_3 (2,1) slice:

```
Q(p,q) += ½ (a₂b₃ Dᵀ + a₃b₂ D) ∘ C0,
```

and with it the step returns 0.999 / 0.999 / 1.004 of the oracle (correlation 0.974 → 0.999) [M]. It costs $O(n^2)$.

(b) The closure. For a Gaussian scale mixture, $\kappa_{4_i} = 3v \cdot \sigma_i^4$; the oracle's κ_{4_i} correlates 0.86 with σ_i^4 at depth. So we keep **one scalar v per layer** and set

```
κ₄ᵢᵢᵢᵢ = 3v·varᵢ²,      K22ᵢⱼ = v·(varᵢ varⱼ + 2C0ᵢⱼ²)
```

(the scale-mixture forms), with v obtained in $O(n^2)$ from the exact identities sum(M) = $u^T X u$ and tr(M) = Σ X_ab G_ab ($u = \mathrm{Wsq}\cdot 1$, $G = \mathrm{Wsq\ Wsq}^T$ with an exact diagonal and a mean-field off-diagonal), which reproduce the transported levels to four digits. The two dense κ_4 products per layer are gone [M].

They only pay together. C0·D on the memo22 chain is *worse* (4.64e-8 against 3.75e-8, three networks); the closure alone is ×1.07; together, with the closure's K22 pattern, ×1.136 on ten networks (3.52e-8 → 3.10e-8), better on 9/10, at –2% of the budget [M]. With the wrong pattern, raising the κ_4 level by the correct diagram makes the error larger; with the right pattern it removes it. → **k3e, graded 9.562e-9.**

3.3 The rest of the first-order scale-mixture set

With the closure in place, the scale mixture predicts three more first-order terms, and again **they only pay together** (each alone is neutral or harmful) [M]: the marginal Edgeworth correction of the pair Wick coefficients, $a_k \to w(k,p) + w(k+3,p)\cdot t/6 + w(k+4,p)\cdot\kappa_4/24$; the closure's κ_4 (3,1) slice, $\kappa_{4_{iii\,j}} = 3v \cdot \mathrm{var}_i \cdot C0_{i\,j}$, entering Q as $\frac{1}{6}(a_3b_1K31 + a_1b_3K31^T)$ (together with the marginal coefficients it cuts the one-step covariance error 0.3% → 0.1%); and the **$\kappa_4 \to \kappa_3$ feed**: all-distinct κ_3 births from the closure's (2,1,1) slice, which in the source representation is Sym(h ⊗ D1C0D1) with $h = (v/2)\cdot d_2 \circ \mathrm{var}$ and rides the existing products (`t += 3 m∘q, D += 2 diag(m) B diag(d₁) Aᵀ + q mᵀ` with $O(n^2)$ extras). The contracted feed matches Monte-Carlo at correlation 0.97–0.98. **The $\kappa_4 \to \kappa_3$ channel was named as**

the main lever of 504aldo's public chain (AIcrowd forum 18218); our form is derived from the closure. Ten networks 3.15e-8 → 2.80e-8 (10/10); 100 networks ×0.880, 100/100 better [M]. → **k3f, graded 8.286e-9.**

3.4 The augmented term set, where it is cheap

Wu et al. also give an "augmented" algorithm; their reference in that mode is ×1.3 more accurate than k3f on our first two networks at ≈2.4× SIMPLE's cost. Against the oracle its κ_3 diagonal is exact to the oracle's noise, while its κ_4 diagonal is *not* better than our σ^4 closure (correlation 0.87 vs 0.86), so the lever is the κ_3 step [M]. We took the part of it that is cheap in our representation: every (1,1,1) "path" birth whose other edge is C0 shares the hub and tree legs, so all of them together are **one extra leg** $\mathrm{Sym}(T{\cdot}Y \otimes 3A \otimes B)$ with $Y = d_1 D^{\mathsf T} d_3 + d_2 D d_2 + \tfrac{1}{2} d_2 K22 d_3 + d_2 C0^2 d_3$ (checked against the reference code to 5e-16), and only its **first readout** matters (age ≤ 1 keeps ~90% of the all-ages gain), so it costs one product per layer; plus the star-diagonal κ_4 birth of the newest source ($O(n^2)$) and the two augmented pair diagrams we lacked, $\tfrac{1}{6} a_3 b_3 C0^3$ and $\tfrac{1}{4} a_3 b_3 C0 \circ K22$ ($O(n^2)$). Ten networks ×1.145 (10/10); 100 networks 98/100 better [M]. → **k3i, graded 6.728e-9.** One level of the closure was then set to a consistent truncation rather than fitted: the closure's K31 sits at 0.74–0.78 of the oracle, the augmented reference, a consistent truncation, at 0.54, and the chain's optimum is a flat 0.6–0.7 (×0.65 shipped; 98/100) [M].

3.5 Consistency: remove a term on both sides, or not at all

This principle moved the score most in the last week of the work. A neuron that the chain treats as absent on one axis must be treated as absent on every axis it appears on; a term whose input is unreliable should go with that input. Its Phase-1 precursor is hyojun_kwon's finding that a learned one-step operator 40% more accurate than the Gaussian closure diverges when iterated, because the closure's value is that it is a stable iterate (AIcrowd forum topic 18154); what follows is the same phenomenon seen from the side of removing terms. Three instances, each **an accuracy gain obtained by removing computation** [M]:

- **Dead neurons.** A neuron with $\alpha = \mu/\sigma < -2.5$ has $d_1 \approx 0$, so every leg row for it is ≈ 0 after gating: we zero those rows exactly and run the next transport over alive rows only (rectangular Strassen, padded to the recursion's quantum): util 26.3% → 24.8% for +1.4% raw (k3m, graded 5.3906e-9). The transpose of that cut, the dead-side **birth columns** of every new source, is also removable exactly, and the two cuts must match: the matched row + column cut beats the row-only cut at every one of five thresholds, by a margin that grows with the gated fraction (matched/row = 0.9985, 0.9970, 0.9928, 0.9790, 0.9475 at –3.0 … –2.0). Production needs per-source column widths, so the legs are stored **transposed**, as one wide stack of hub rows, which turns the transport into one row-stack product and the D pairing into one contraction. 100 networks ×0.950 adjusted, **100/100** (k3o, graded 5.1127e-9).
- **Saturated rows of D (E2).** Rows of D for neurons saturated now ($\alpha > 2.5$) reach the step only through the tail coefficients $\mathrm{coef}(2,1) = d_2 + d_5 t/6 + d_6 \kappa_4/24$, whose Edgeworth correction is –28 … –79% of d_2 there; the marginal series is at the edge of validity. Removing those rows naively costs ×1.34 at 2.5, and **all** of that damage is the κ_4 level the next layer reads through $\mathrm{Ssum} = u^{\mathsf T} K22 u$; restoring that level by a matrix-vector product ($dS = \Sigma_i u_i \, cf22_i \, (D\,v)_i$) turns the cut into an accuracy **gain**: raw ×0.943 (k3q, graded 4.1279e-9).
- **marg2, the pair expansion's one defect.** Keeping the marginal correction of the k = 2 Wick coefficient only in the dead tail ($\alpha \le -2$) and using the plain Gaussian w(2,p) elsewhere (in Q11, Q21 *and* Q22 together; in one power cumulant alone it is ×1.09–1.11 worse) is worth ×0.984 on 32 fresh networks (cloud session #9A) and ×0.981 on ten locally, at zero FLOPs (k3r, graded 4.0579e-9). A later generative screen of seven next-order pair diagrams found exactly two that help, C0·K31 and

D^2, and both are **substitutes** for marg2 (×1.008 together with it): the pair expansion has one defect, in its k = 2 leg, and marg2 is its cleanest form.

3.6 Old sources in a basis that rides the transport

Sources older than a0 = 5 layers no longer carry their own legs. They live as P·Z in one shared basis P (n × 448): P^T rides the leg transport as 448 extra rows (gated and contracted over alive rows like any leg), and since $W^T\mathrm{diag}(d_1)(PZ) = (W^T\mathrm{diag}(d_1)P)Z$ the coefficients Z **never change**. A source enters once, projected on the current P through a QR ($Z = R^{-1}Q^TX$); P is never re-orthonormalised and Z never rotated. The members are materialised each layer by one product for the readout, and their part of D is paired in the compressed space, $(L_m^T\ Z^T)P^T$. 100 networks ×0.893 adjusted, **100/100** better (k3p, graded 4.5644e-9) [M]. Both band knobs sit at sharp optima (rank 320 / 384 / 448 / 512: ×1.228 / 1.032 / 1 / 1.033; entry age 4 / 5 / 6: ×1.125 / 1 / 1.016) [M]. Why this compression works where the re-fitted subspace of §6.1 did not is the subject of that section: the basis is never rebuilt.

3.7 A learned correction of the κ_4 diagonal

The idea is mliston's (AIcrowd forum 18170, Phase 1): a model trained offline on self-generated networks to predict the closure's error from its own propagating state, frozen into the estimator as constants. No code of theirs was seen or used. Our version and what we learned testing it:

- From the neuron's **own** moments the damaging error is invisible (§6.4); the κ_4 diagonal is the exception because its error has an environment-dependent level, which **O(n²) row reductions of matrices the chain already holds**, C0, D and K22, can see. The model is a ridge regression (λ = 1e-3) of the relative κ_4 error on 39 features (21 functions of the neuron's own moments, 17 such row reductions, the layer index), applied at layers 8–14 with shrinkage 0.5 (not tuned); 118 numbers, trained on the production trajectory of 10 public networks against our own Monte-Carlo oracles (two at 10^7 samples, eight at $2{\cdot}10^6$).
- **Two networks are not enough** (fit on one, apply to the other: ×1.00–1.08); ten are, and thirty are not better (held-out R^2 0.353 vs 0.354) [M].
- **The validation ladder**, each step less optimistic than the one above it [M]: in sample ×0.92 → ten-fold leave-one- network-out ×0.974 → online ×0.968 → through the production estimator ×0.980 → **87 networks never seen ×0.988 (69/87)** → **the grader ×0.988** (raw 2.0559e-8 → 2.0312e-8).
- The same construction for the variance or κ_3 **hurts**, in sample and out (§6.4). → **k3v, graded 3.9102e-9.**

3.8 Exact arithmetic

Strassen–Winograd as flopscope operations (deepened only where a contraction pays for its wall time), the symmetric C_pre computed as three blocks of four, an explicit triangular inverse where flopscope bills `solve` as an LU, and Winograd's 15-addition form change the FLOP bill and move the output only by float rounding. They are engineering, and they are in Appendix A.1 with their measurements; here only the record: k3t, k3w, k3x, k3y and k3z together are ×0.931 of the ×0.693 from 5.39e-9 to 3.74e-9, and each landed on the grader as projected [M].

4. Cost: where the budget goes, and what binds it

The score is `mean_m( final_layer_mse_m × max(0.1, C_m/B) )` with `B = 2⁴¹` FLOPs per network as billed by flopscope. Two features of that formula shaped every decision in §3.

It is a product, so relative percentages are interchangeable. At our operating point 1% of utilisation and 1% of MSE are worth exactly the same, which is why every lever in this document is reported as a

pair (raw ×, util ×) and why several terms that *improve accuracy* are absent from the shipped estimator: they improve it by less than they cost.

The multiplier floors at 0.1. Above 10% of the budget every FLOP is charged linearly; at or below it FLOPs are free and only accuracy matters. We never got under the floor (k3z: 18.33%). At our raw error, the floor alone would have been worth ×0.55: 2.03e-9, about 10th place on the board of 2026-10-16, and §6.1–6.2 are the record of why it could not be reached with this representation.

4.1 The measured cost map of the shipped estimator

We stopped pricing levers with a cost model after it was wrong by 3.5×, by 9× and in sign within one day (§6.1 records what that model said yes to). The map below is the meter itself: the shipped estimator with a `flopscope.namespace` around every call site (a copy verified bitwise against the shipped file), run through the official runner on one public network [M]:

call site	what it is	FLOPs	backend time
leg transport	the young sources' legs and the band basis P^T moved one layer (Strassen level 5)	**23.5%**	19.3%
D pairing	the (2,1) slice from the non-members' legs (level 5)	**19.9%**	20.9%
band members	the old sources' legs materialised from the basis, for the readout (level 5)	**16.7%**	**24.2%**
members' pairing	the old sources' part of D, paired in the compressed space (level 4)	11.8%	10.6%
band entry	QR of the basis, projection, explicit triangular inverse	8.2%	4.4%
covariance	C and the newest path leg transported (level 5), C_pre = $W^T(CW)$ (3 of 4 blocks, level 5)	11.5%	13.4%
the step's mathematics	the whole pair expansion **0.43%**, the κ_4 closure 0.06%, its learned corrector 0.05%, the readout 1.9%, the births 0.9%	**3.3%**	2.9%
the rest	pairing preparation, thin legs, the E2 level restoration, gathers and gating	5.1%	4.3%

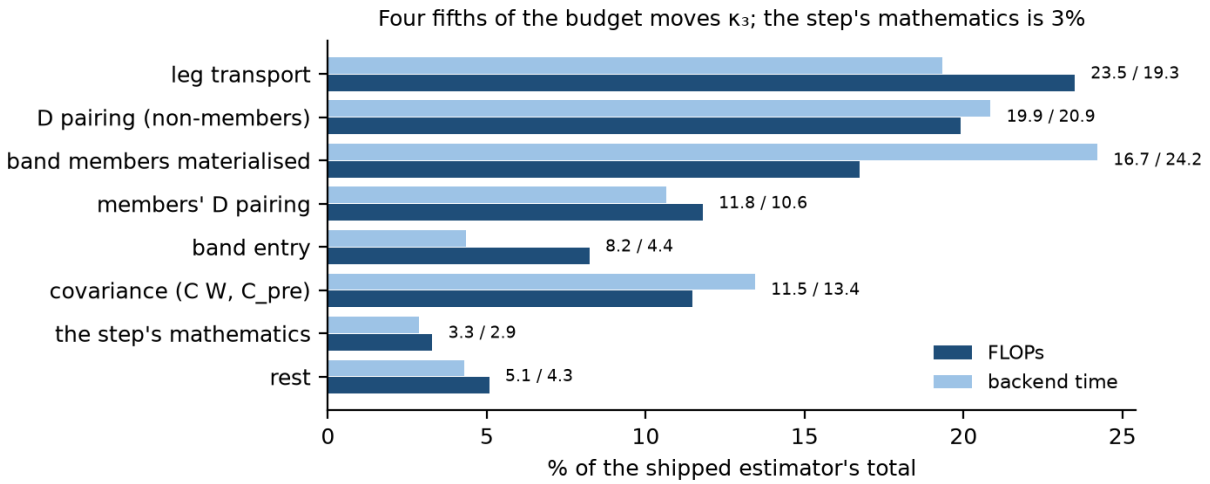


Figure 2. The table as a picture: share of the designated estimator's FLOPs (dark) and of flopscope's backend time (light) by call site, one network, `flopscope.namespace()` on a bitwise copy of k3z.

Four fifths of the budget is the logistics of carrying the third cumulant forward; the mathematics that decides the answer is 3%. Two consequences follow, and both shaped the work. Any accuracy term that lives in the step, such as a new pair diagram, a closure pattern or the learned corrector, is free, which is why §3.2–§3.5 and §3.7 cost nothing measurable. And any real cost saving has to come out of the representation of κ_3, which §6.1 and §6.2 show is the one place no cheap construction exists. The level-5 sites run at 8–14 billed GFLOP/s against 17–30 for level-4 and element-wise work: deeper Strassen recursion buys FLOPs with wall time.

4.2 The configuration sits at the kink of its own cost/accuracy curve

Eight structural knobs were measured in both directions on ten networks: the band rank and entry age, re-opening all source ages for the path births, a larger thin rank, the $\kappa_4 \to \kappa_3$ coupling, and others. The elasticity |d log raw / d log util| is **below 1 in every direction that spends more** (band rank 512: 0.43; entry age 6: 0.56; all ages: 0.25; thin rank 384: 0.10; $\kappa_4\kappa_3$: 0.05) and **above 1 in every direction that spends less** (rank 384: 1.54; entry age 4: 3.76) [M]. The product raw × util is minimised exactly where the estimator ships; a fifty-three-switch catalogue re-screened by a cloud session found no switch that improves it either (12 of 53 improve raw, none the score).

4.3 The budgets that are not the meter

Three caps zero a network's prediction when crossed (400 ms of non-flopscope time, 120 s of wall time, 8 GB of memory), and in practice they, not the FLOP count, set the depth of every engineering choice. Their measurements, the Strassen depth they allow and the designation they imply are in Appendix A.2–A.3.

5. Results

5.1 Every structural lever landed on its projection

Before shipping, every version was run on our 100 public networks with the official runner; the projection for the grader is that local score times the measured local→grader ratio of the previous version. The last ten versions [M]:

submission	version	what changed (§)	projected	graded	util	wall max / residual max (grader)
333028	k3o	matched dead-side cut (3.5)	5.12e-9	**5.1127e-9**	23.8%	— / 0.178 s
333029	k3p	old sources in a riding basis (3.6)	4.57e-9	**4.5644e-9**	20.7%	— / 0.233 s
333276	k3q	E2, the saturated rows of D (3.5)	4.14e-9	**4.1279e-9**	19.7%	63.7 s / 0.247 s
333307	k3r	marg2 (3.5)	4.06e-9	**4.0579e-9**	19.7%	69.7 s / 0.262 s
333357	k3t	level 5 on three contractions (A.1)	3.95e-9	**3.9554e-9**	19.2%	82.1 s / 0.268 s
333368	k3v	the learned κ_4 corrector (3.7)	3.91e-9	**3.9102e-9**	19.3%	81.2 s / 0.277 s
333388	k3w	level 5 on the band members (A.1)	3.86e-9	**3.8576e-9**	18.9%	92.2 s / 0.288 s

submission	version	what changed (§)	projected	graded	util	wall max / residual max (grader)
333398	k3x	level 5 on the D pairing (A.1)	3.80e-9	**3.8069e-9**	18.7%	95.2 s / 0.281 s
333402	k3y	symmetric C_pre, explicit triangular R^{-1} (A.1)	3.76e-9	**3.7573e-9**	18.4%	97.6 s / 0.310 s
333534	**k3z**	Winograd's 15-addition form, level 5 inside the C_pre halves (A.1)	3.735e-9	**3.7357e-9**	**18.3%**	98.8 s / 0.331 s

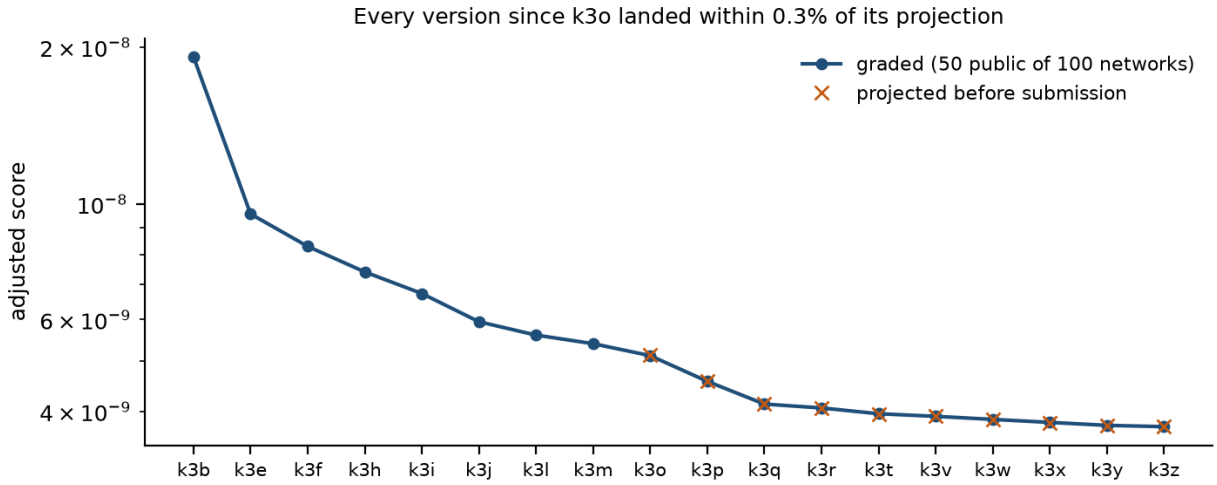


Figure 3. Graded score of every k = 3 version that improved our graded best (log scale), from the first graded k = 3 submission (k3b, 1.9e-8) to the designated one; crosses mark the projection made before each of the last ten submissions.

The designated submission, **333534**, ran on all 100 grader networks (50 public, 50 sealed) with 0 failures; its raw error is 2.0317e-8, its utilisation 18.3%, its wall time 91.2 s median and 98.8 s maximum of the 120 s cap. Compared with the reference algorithm we started from (raw 4.25e-8 at 148% of the budget), the method is ×2.1 more accurate at ×8 less compute; compared with covariance propagation (4.05e-7 adjusted), the score is ×108 better.

The table should be read against §6.5. A fitted scalar that improved 66 of 100 local networks came out 0.13% worse on the grader; the ten structural or exact changes above, each validated the same way, landed within 0.3% of their projections. The one learned component (k3v) behaved like a structural one because it was validated on 87 networks it had never seen before it shipped.

5.2 What each component is worth on the final stack

The production estimator (k3y; the designated k3z differs from it only by exact FLOP savings) with ONE switch turned off at a time, on public networks 0–31, and separately on 10–31, on which none of the method's fitted choices (the corrector's training set, the cut thresholds, K31's level) was made [M]. Ratios against the switch on; each arm is compared with a base run on the same machine (M = laptop, C = a cloud session: per-network float32 rounding differs between the two by up to ±4%, the FLOPs by $\leq 3 \cdot 10^{-6}$).

switched off	§	adjusted × (0–31)	raw ×	util ×	networks worse	adjusted × (10–31)	run
the marginal Edgeworth pair coefficients	3.3	**×1.558**	×1.558	×1.000	32/32	×1.547 (22/22)	M
the matched dead-neuron cuts (rows and birth columns)	3.5	**×1.433**	×1.237	×1.159	32/32	×1.420 (22/22)	C
the edge × κ_3 diagram C0·D	3.2	**×1.303**	×1.304	×0.999	32/32	×1.299 (22/22)	M
the closure's κ_4 (3,1) slice K31	3.3	**×1.166**	×1.167	×0.999	32/32	×1.163 (22/22)	M
E2: saturated rows of D out, κ_4 level restored	3.5	**×1.137**	×1.065	×1.067	32/32	×1.138 (22/22)	M
the path births (augmented (1,1,1) births at the first readout)	3.4	**×1.099**	×1.145	×0.959	32/32	×1.092 (22/22)	M
the riding band (old sources carried densely)	3.6	**×1.098**	×0.973	×1.128	32/32	×1.098 (22/22)	C
the $\kappa_4 \to \kappa_3$ feed	3.3	**×1.093**	×1.096	×0.997	30/32	×1.101 (21/22)	M
K31 at the closure's own level (×1 instead of ×0.65)	3.4	**×1.071**	×1.072	×1.000	32/32	×1.072 (22/22)	M
Strassen level 5 (level 4 everywhere)	A.1	**×1.052**	×1.000	×1.052	32/32	×1.052 (22/22)	M
the dead-side birth-column cut alone	3.5	**×1.051**	×1.004	×1.048	31/32	×1.048 (22/22)	M
marg2 (Gaussian k = 2 pair coefficient outside the dead tail)	3.5	**×1.020**	×1.020	×1.000	30/32	×1.020 (21/22)	M
the learned κ_4-diagonal corrector	3.7	**×1.013**	×1.014	×0.999	23/32	×1.010 (15/22)	C
symmetric C_pre and the explicit triangular R^{-1}	A.1	**×1.013**	×1.000	×1.013	32/32	×1.013 (22/22)	M
the star-diagonal κ_4 birth	3.4	**×1.012**	×1.012	×1.000	24/32	×1.012 (16/22)	M
the augmented pair diagrams $C0^3$ and C0∘K22	3.4	**×1.007**	×1.008	×0.999	24/32	×1.008 (19/22)	M

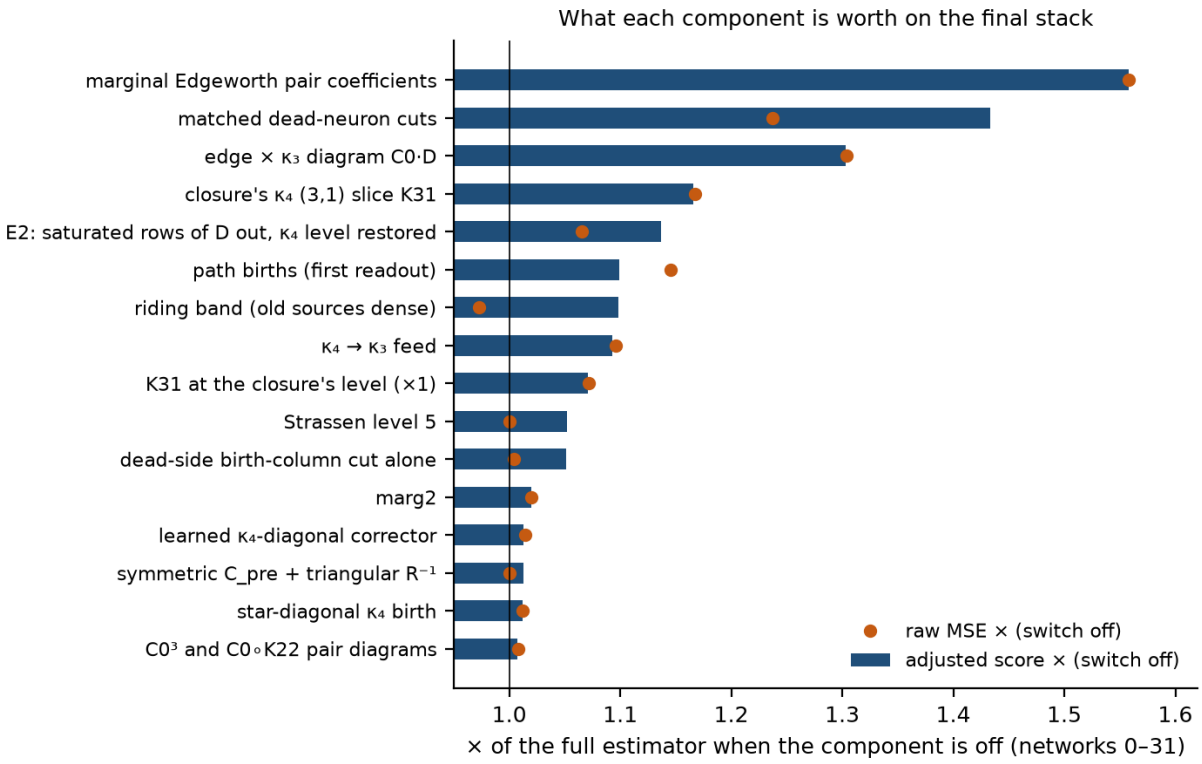


Figure 4. The table as a picture: adjusted score × (bars) and raw error × (dots) when one component is switched off, networks 0–31. The first-order scale-mixture set and the consistency cuts carry the method; the cost levers trade FLOPs for little or no accuracy.

Three things stand out [M]. **The step's first-order scale-mixture set is the most valuable part of the method, and it is free:** without the marginal Edgeworth pair coefficients the error is ×1.56, without the edge × κ_3 diagram C0·D ×1.30, without the closure's K31 ×1.17, all of them O(n^2); then the path births ×1.10, the $\kappa_4 \to \kappa_3$ feed ×1.09 and K31's truncation level ×1.07. On the final stack each of them is load-bearing even though, as §3 showed, none of them paid alone when it was added: the consistency of §3.5 seen from the other end. **The consistency cuts are accuracy gains as well as savings:** with the matched dead cuts off, raw error is ×1.24 worse; with E2 off, ×1.07. **The cost levers buy FLOPs with little or no accuracy:** the riding band costs 3% of raw error and saves 11% of the bill; level-5 Strassen and the symmetric/triangular savings change the output only by rounding. The one learned component is worth ×1.010 out of its training sample, the value it showed on the grader ($\times 0.988^{-1} = \times 1.012$). Every component worth more than 5% makes at least 30 of the 32 networks worse when removed, and the 22 networks outside every fitted choice give the same ratios to the second digit.

5.3 Where the remaining error is

§2 and §6.4 are the answer: four fifths of the final error is born in the kink core of every layer; at depth 95% of the next layer's variance error is a random projection of the off-diagonal covariance error through independent weights; and the step's two pair inputs carry errors (7% in D, 20% in K22) that are worth fixing only all together. The oracle bound for fixing every per-neuron moment at once is ×0.2–0.3 of our raw error. The representation lacks the joint structure that would make those moments right, not a term.

6. The boundary: four mechanisms that decide what is possible here

We think this section and §7 are the contribution. §3 is a sequence of terms that pay; this section is a map of why the remaining ideas do not, and the map is made of measurements. Each mechanism is stated as a rule, with the prediction it makes about ideas we never tried. Over three weeks we catalogued seventy-six negative results with numbers (the repository's `notes/NEGATIVE-RESULTS.md`; we cite its entries as N1–N76, which the repository's own notes write as §1–§76); the four mechanisms below account for every one that failed for a reason more interesting than a bug or a budget.

6.1 A cost model that prices the saved product and not the construction says yes every time

Every attempt below has the same shape. Some object in the chain costs `k` dense n^3 products per layer. A compression exists that would carry the same information in `q·k` products, `q < 1`. The cost model says the saving is `(1−q)·k`, and the accuracy measurement says the compression is affordable. **Then the construction that produces the compressed object turns out to cost at least as much as the saving.** Five independent instances, each closed by its own measurement [M]:

#	what was to be compressed	modelled saving	what the construction cost	net
N54	old sources onto a shared subspace (band 6:320, *re-rotated every layer*)	26.3% → 21.4% of budget, ×1.20	the per-layer entry update (Gram applications, QR, `eigh`, coefficient rotation ≈ 4–7 products per band source-layer)	**27.78% measured, i.e. worse than the 26.62% baseline**
N55	the path leg at rank ρ = 256 (`pathrank`)	–0.7 points of B for +0.66% MSE	the rank-ρ basis: `YΩ` + `QᵀY` (2q) on top of `WᵀQ` + `(WᵀQ)Z` (2q) = **4q = 1.0 units at ρ = 256**, before a `qr` worth 0.125	break-even *before* the QR; measured on the meter at rank 384: **×1.0495 of the dense leg**
N58	the old κ_3 tail as one rank-n block	24.14% → 12.69–13.87%, ≈ **8.8 units per layer**, and a rank-n block provably **exists** (n = 64, converged to 4.29e-4)	one Gram-form fitting pass is `8·n·R·r` flops = **8.0 units**, so the budget is *one pass*; 400 passes reach 4.32% **and are still falling**	**≈400× gap**, and no warm start: adding one source to a converged block throws the error 2.9% → **48.7%**, because the CP optimum **is not nested**
N59	the same block by unbiased sampling ($O(n^2)$, no passes, nested by construction)	the budget is 3–5% relative error	the estimator's own variance: relative error ≈ $\kappa/\sqrt{r}$ with **$\kappa = \|\text{term}\|/\|T\| = 62.08$**	**194% at r = n**; 5% would need $r \approx 1.5\cdot10^6$ columns against the 15 360 the tail contains

#	what was to be compressed	modelled saving	what the construction cost	net
N76	the old tier read through a smaller per-layer optimal basis ($r' < 448$), or truncated by age, or its D taken from the young sources only	$r' = 256$ would save ≈8% of the FLOPs; dropping the three oldest sources 11% of the member-layers	the content itself: reading the members in 256 dimensions costs ×1.11–1.15 raw and in 128 ×2.7–3.1; the three oldest sources dropped ×1.17; D from the young sources only ×9.25	**the band at rank 448 and entry age 5 is the cheapest exact-enough carrier in this family** (both knobs are sharp optima, §3.6)

The five share one cause: the accounting was incomplete. A compression has two costs, transporting the compressed object and producing it, and only the first is what a "this would be cheaper" estimate naturally counts. The second is paid every layer, because the object being compressed is regenerated every layer by the nonlinearity.

The counter-example that confirms the rule. One compression of the old sources *does* ship (§3.6): a basis of fixed rank 448 that **rides the transport**: it is moved by the same products as the legs and never re-built, re-rotated or re-orthonormalised, so its construction cost is paid once per source, at its entry. Its condition number grows ≈2.5× per layer (to $7 \cdot 10^4$ by the last entry) and that is harmless, because nothing ever needs it orthonormal again [M]. The difference from N54 is exactly the term the rule says to price.

The prediction we would hand the next person. Before building any compression of a propagated object, price the *basis*, per layer. For a projection onto `r` directions the basis needs at least one pass over the object (`q` units) plus one to express the object in it (`q`), plus orthogonalisation; for a CP-type re-parameterisation it needs a solver, and N58 shows the solver has no warm start. The saving must beat **all** of that, or the basis must ride the transport for free.

Budgets other than the meter. Exact arithmetic savings obey a different rule, and we report it because the grader enforces it. One more Strassen-Winograd level everywhere (leaf 64 → 32) bills ×0.939 of the FLOPs, changes the output by ~1e-6, and doubles the wall time (×2.2; ≈140 s projected against the 120 s cap) at a peak RSS of 7.21 GB of 8 GB (N69) [M]: a 32×32 leaf has no BLAS efficiency left. Pricing each contraction separately by **FLOPs saved per second of wall added** (0.49 %/s for the leg transport down to 0.27 %/s for the D pairing) and deepening only where it pays recovered most of that ×0.939 on five sites, inside the cap (grader wall 98.8 s max); the next site measured at 0.094 %/s (both of its products have a 448-wide side, so its level-5 leaves are 14 wide) and was not taken [M].

6.2 The principle underneath the four: the third cumulant is not closed on the slices the step reads

The four instances in §6.1 are failures of *representations*. The question that sits under all of them is whether the κ_3 tensor needs to be represented at all, since the nonlinear step reads only two of its slices, the diagonal t and the (2,1) slice D. We measured that directly.

With the leg transport $M = W^{T} \cdot \mathrm{diag}(d_1)$ (verified to reproduce the chain's own transport to ≤ 5.1e-16), the next layer's diagonal splits exactly, by coincidence pattern of the three indices, into a t-term ($\Sigma_j M_{ij}^3 t_j$), a D-term ($3 \Sigma_{j \neq k} M_{ij}^2 M_{ik} D_{jk}$), and an **all-distinct** term $\Sigma_{j,k,m \text{ distinct}} M_{ij} M_{ik} M_{im} T_{jkm}$, which we obtain as a remainder without ever forming n^3 (closed forms checked against brute force to 6e-17 and 4.3e-16). Then:

quantity	measured (n = 1024)
share of the next diagonal carried by the all-distinct term	**28.8%** per layer (layers ≥ 8; 27.2–31.2%)
a chain whose κ_3 state is (t, D) only, end-to-end	**raw ×25.6** (compounding: $1.288^{14} \approx 34$)
fraction of the all-distinct term a closer must capture to stay within 3% raw	**≥ 93%**
best oracle closer on any $O(n^2)$ basis we could construct	**19.5%**
of which re-fitting the t- and D-coefficients	**0.16%** — the missing part is orthogonal to both (corr ±0.03); the D-coefficient fits to 1.000

So a (t, D) state is insufficient, and what is missing is **orthogonal to everything computable in $O(n^2)$**. That is a statement one level above §6.1: the κ_3 state must carry $\Theta(n^3)$ information forward, and the cost of this chain is the price of that information. The contrast that explains why our κ_4 closure (§3.2) works and a κ_3 closure cannot is worth one line: κ_4 enters the readout at second order, whereas κ_3 *is* the readout, so its tolerance is an order of magnitude tighter.

Why 28.8%, derived. The share is not a property of our arithmetic; it follows from how the gated κ_3 tensor's energy is spread over index patterns.

> **Proposition 3 (the share the slices do not carry).** Let $G = T \circ (d_1 \otimes d_1 \otimes d_1)$ be layer l's κ_3 tensor with the gates on its legs, $v_a = \Sigma_b G_{abb}$ its partial trace, and G_{AD} its entries with three different indices. With W(l+1) i.i.d. $N(0, 2/n)$ and independent of G, the part of the next diagonal that (t, D) do not determine has, for every neuron,
>
> $\text{share}^2 = E\|AD\|^2 / E\|t'\|^2 = 6\|G_{AD}\|^2_F / (6\|G\|^2_F + 9\|v\|^2)$. [D]
>
> *Proof.* $t'_i = \Sigma_{abc} w_a w_b w_c G_{abc}$ with w the i-th column of W(l+1). Isserlis' theorem for the sixth moment of a Gaussian vector gives 15 pairings: the 6 that match the two triples give $6s^6\|G\|^2$, the 9 that pair inside each triple give $9s^6\|v\|^2$. Terms with three distinct indices survive only the 6 matching pairings and are uncorrelated with every term that repeats an index. ∎

Measured (random networks of depth 16, the dense tensor built from the chain's own sources, the share taken with the network's own next weights): the ratio of measured to predicted share is 0.94 ± 0.15 at n = 64, 1.00 ± 0.12 at 128 and 0.99 ± 0.06 at 256 (layers ≥ 8), the scatter shrinking as $1/\sqrt{n}$ [M]. On the true κ_3 tensor, estimated by Monte Carlo (two seeds of $2 \cdot 10^6$ samples, energies as cross products), the ratio is 0.94 ± 0.10 at n = 64, 1.01 ± 0.13 at n = 128 and 0.97 ± 0.04 at n = 256: the share is a property of the network family, not of our chain [M] (`experiments/2026-10-14_vm` §9). Most of the tensor's energy is all-distinct (72% → 88% from n = 64 to 256), but the partial trace weighs more still and grows faster ($9\|v\|^2/6\|G\|^2 = 2.1 \to 4.6$), so the share falls only slowly with width: 46% → 40% over that range and 28.8% at 1024. No practical width closes κ_3 on its slices. And v points almost exactly along the post-activation mean vector m, cos(v, m) = +0.92 … +0.99 [M], which has a consequence for the next section: the dominant part of a neuron's next κ_3 is a multiple of its own next mean (`experiments/2026-10-13_prop3`).

The larger-state door, closed by the same principle. If the slices are not enough, a richer $O(n^2)$ state might be: we let the old tail evolve as a Markov chain of its own slices (`MST`, N66). Its all-distinct share is 27–28%, so the old tail is exactly as non-slice as the young, and the chain it gives is dominated by ours at every age threshold [M].

Independent replication. While we were measuring this, team 504aldo published on the public forum, with their code under MIT, a catalogue of 25 dead ends for the same chain at the same shape (AIcrowd Discourse topic 18218, 2026-09-10). Their rows match ours almost one for one: a memoryless closure on the (2,1)/(3,) slices is 45× worse, "the lost part is 18–23% of D21 energy per layer, high-rank, not predictable from live-state features (+0.02 R^2)" (our 28.8%); a CP-rank cap on the merged tensor needs 8n columns for 3–14% D21 error where 2% is needed, with "flat column importance" (our N58); learned output corrections see features correlated < 0.09 with the error (ours ≤ 0.03); and their row 21 states our mechanism in their own words: "forming a leg from the basis costs what transporting it costs; this is THE wall". Two teams, different code, different ground-truth instruments, the same walls. We think that turns "we could not" into "this family of representations cannot", which is the claim we make.

What neither team explains, and we say so: 504aldo observe that their bill *without* the old tier is 0.150·B, and that the top three entries sat at 0.149, 0.152 and 0.164·B on the same day with better raw error than either of us. Whatever carries the leaders' old-source content costs them approximately nothing. It is not a compression of the source representation, both catalogues rule that out, and we do not know what it is. [U] The public board of 2026-10-16 says what that is worth: teams at about our raw error (1.95–2.05e-8) sit at 10–19% of the budget, one of them at rank 11 on the 10% floor. Our raw error at that floor would score 2.03e-9, about 10th place against our 55th; the cost of carrying κ_3 alone is worth some forty places [M].

6.3 Coherence decides whether a cheap correction can help at all

Prior work. The mechanism of this section was published first, in Phase 1 at depth 32, by jamesrahenry (AIcrowd Discourse 18097; summarised in the Phase-1 technique census, 18157, item 1c): the chain is an error-compensating system in which zero-mean perturbations damp while coherent injected corrections amplify, at a measured ~16:1. We rediscovered it independently at depth 16 and credit it here. What this section adds is the Phase-2 measurement — a variance-level parabola ~1e-5 wide, the incoherent/coherent ratio 44 ≈ √n — and its second, less obvious use in (b) below, where the same argument explains why a same-sign sum *cannot* be sampled.

The scored quantity is a mean over n = 1024 neurons of a quantity built from same-sign contributions. That one fact sets the value of every correction we might add, through the distinction between an error that is **coherent** across neurons (a smooth function of smooth per-neuron quantities) and one that is **incoherent** (independent per neuron). The coherent part is paid in full; the incoherent part is discounted by √n. Two measurements pin it down, and they point in opposite directions, which is the useful part.

(a) The variance channel: the chain is already at the bottom of a parabola 1e-5 wide. Substituting the Monte-Carlo oracle's exact per-neuron pre-activation variance at every layer is worth ×1.54 on the final MSE, so the channel is large. But scaling the variance by a constant, `var ← var(1+c)`, gives

> final MSE ≈ 2.4e-8 + 5·c^2, minimum at **c ≈ 0 to within 3e-5**; c = 1e-4 costs **×2.7**, c = 1e-3 costs ×200.

The *level* is therefore already correct to about 1e-5 relative, and every low-parameter correction of the *pattern* we tried is **worse than doing nothing**: a per-layer level −0.59×, level plus a log-variance term −0.54×, a seven-feature per-layer least squares −0.535×, with the fit explaining only **R^2 = 0.098** of the error. The reason is coherence: a smooth function of (α, log var, κ_4/var^2, …) is smooth across neurons, so it acts coherently and is charged at the coherent rate, while the part of the error it captures is incoherent and worth √n less. Measured directly: an rms pattern error of 1.8e-3 at depth costs the same as a *coherent* shift of 4.1e-5, a ratio of **44 ≈ √n**.

The same argument explains a result we had previously mis-read as evidence of error cancellation: that substituting an "exact" covariance made things worse (N50). It did, because the substitution was fed by a $4{\cdot}10^6$-sample oracle whose own noise, 6.6e-4 relative, is *coherent* in exactly this sense.

A methodological trap worth one paragraph, because it cost us an hour and it will cost the next person more. A multiplicative correction measured on the base trajectory is **stale from the next layer on**: once the variance is touched, the chain's own variance moves, so a factor calibrated as `var_true/var_chain` no longer lands on `var_true`. At a stiffness of ×2.7 per 1e-4, that drift alone reads as a ×0.658 "result" for an arm that should be the ×1.54 ceiling. Only corrections that are a **function of the current state** can be tested, which is also the only kind production could compute.

(b) The κ_3 tail: same-sign in the readout, nearly orthogonal in the norm that matters. The tail of old sources carries ≈69% of ‖t‖ at depth and its terms are same-sign, which is why every *truncation* of it fails coherently: dropping the light terms of a same-sign sum loses their whole mass. That observation is what made unbiased importance sampling look like the answer: an unbiased estimator keeps the mass in expectation, and its error is a random fluctuation rather than a systematic loss. It fails anyway, for this reason:

> sampling variance is governed by the **Frobenius norm of the tensor**, not by the diagonal readout, and in that norm the tail's terms are nearly orthogonal: **$\kappa/\sqrt{R} = 0.50$**, against 0.008 for perfect coherence and 1.0 for full orthogonality.

Same-sign `t` and near-orthogonal `T` are not in conflict: `t` is one diagonal of the tensor, while sampling damages all of it. **So "the terms add coherently" is a statement about a particular contraction, and it does not transfer to a different norm.** We had the right mechanism and applied it in the wrong norm; the measurement corrected us.

6.4 The next layer's per-neuron errors are random projections of this layer's joint errors

The third boundary explains the second family of failures: everything we tried that *learns* a correction of the chain's per-neuron moments. It is a small theorem, stated after a cloud session had measured the object it is about.

> **Proposition 1 (per-neuron variance errors are random projections).** Let `ΔC(l) = C_chain(l) − C(l)` be the error of the chain's post-activation covariance at layer `l`, and `ΔC₀` the same matrix with its diagonal removed. Let `w_i` be the i-th column of `W(l+1)`, with i.i.d. N(0, 2/n) entries. The chain computes the next layer's pre-activation variances exactly from its own covariance, so its error for neuron i is
>
> $e_i = w_i^T \Delta C\, w_i = \Sigma_j\, w_{ji}^2\, \Delta C_{jj} + w_i^T \Delta C_0\, w_i.$
>
> Conditioned on ΔC: the first term has mean $(2/n){\cdot}\mathrm{tr}\,\Delta C$, the same for every neuron, with a fluctuation of relative size $1/\sqrt{n}$; the second has mean zero and variance $8\|\Delta C_0\|_F^2 / n^2$; and the e_i are independent across neurons. [D]
>
> *Proof.* ΔC(l) is a function of `W_0, …, W_l` only, so it is independent of `W(l+1)`. Given ΔC, the quadratic form in the Gaussian vector w_i has mean $(2/n){\cdot}\mathrm{tr}\,\Delta C$, all of it from the diagonal because $E[w_{ji} w_{ki}] = 0$ for $j \neq k$; the off-diagonal part has variance $\Sigma_{j\neq k}\, 2{\cdot}(2/n)^2{\cdot}\Delta C_{jk}^2 = 8\|\Delta C_0\|_F^2 / n^2$; the columns w_i are independent given ΔC, hence so are the e_i. ∎

Measured. On network 0's real matrices the ratio of the observed off-diagonal energy to that prediction is 0.89–1.09 at every layer and its mean is at most 0.05 of its rms at 14 of 15 layers (0.10 at one; $1/\sqrt{n}$ =

0.03). Against four 10^7-sample oracles of the full post-activation covariance (two per network, noise subtracted with their difference), the off-diagonal term carries **95% of the energy of the next layer's variance error** (90–105% at every layer ≥ 3, on both networks; Figure 5) [M].

Consequence 1: no per-neuron model can see the error that matters. The only per-neuron features correlated with $w_i^\top \Delta C_0 w_i$ are quadratic forms of the neuron's own weight column against an n×n matrix, such as its own variance $w_i^\top C w_i$, which sees only the part of ΔC_0 proportional to C (5–14% of the signal, Consequence 3). A model of the moment error on summaries of the neuron's state sees the coherent level, that small part, and noise [D]. This is what we had measured *before* we understood it [M]: removing the projection of the exact moment error onto 20 smooth per-neuron features buys ×1.015 / ×0.957, while removing the remainder buys ×0.269 / ×0.450 of a ×0.206 / ×0.302 joint ceiling (N70); a joint variance + κ_4 corrector looks synergistic in sample (×0.885 against ×0.916 for κ_4 alone) and has a held-out variance R^2 of **0.004** across ten networks; out of sample the variance channel makes it worse (N71).

Consequence 2: the one exception, and why. The κ_4 diagonal's error is not purely a projection: it has a level that depends on the neuron's environment, and O(n^2) row reductions of the matrices the chain already holds (C0, D, K22) see it: held-out R^2 0.36, and the shipped corrector is worth ×0.988 on the grader, exactly its out-of-sample local value (§3.7) [M]. Own-moment features alone see nothing (N70) [M].

Consequence 3: the reserve is real, and diffuse. Substituting the exact off-diagonal covariance at every layer would be worth **×0.55–0.68** (an oracle upper bound, noise-corrected two ways) [M]. Nothing cheap carries it [M]:

- **low rank:** two eigendirections reproducible across oracle seeds at 0.99, aligned with the post-mean vector, hold 40–65% of $\|\Delta C_0\|^2$ at depth and buy ×0.93–1.07; the payoff appears only from rank ~64 and lives in the bulk;
- **sparsity:** the top 1% of entries buy nothing; two thirds of the payoff needs the top 20% of all pairs, chosen by the oracle; the top pairs are large-|D|, large-|C0| pairs, not kink-core pairs;
- **prediction:** a linear model of ΔC_0 on 27 O(n^2) matrices of the chain (every term of its pair expansion, six candidate diagrams it lacks, its own C and C^2, gain-type features) explains **≤ 10% in sample and ≤ 6% out of sample** against a split-half noise ceiling of 0.87–0.98; proportional ($\Delta C_0 \propto$ C0) and per-neuron-gain models are neutral or harmful;
- **where it comes from:** 65–76% of ΔC_0 at depth was *carried* through earlier, independent weights; the part born at the current step (the step run on the exact input covariance) is 22–30% and only 6–15% linear in local features.

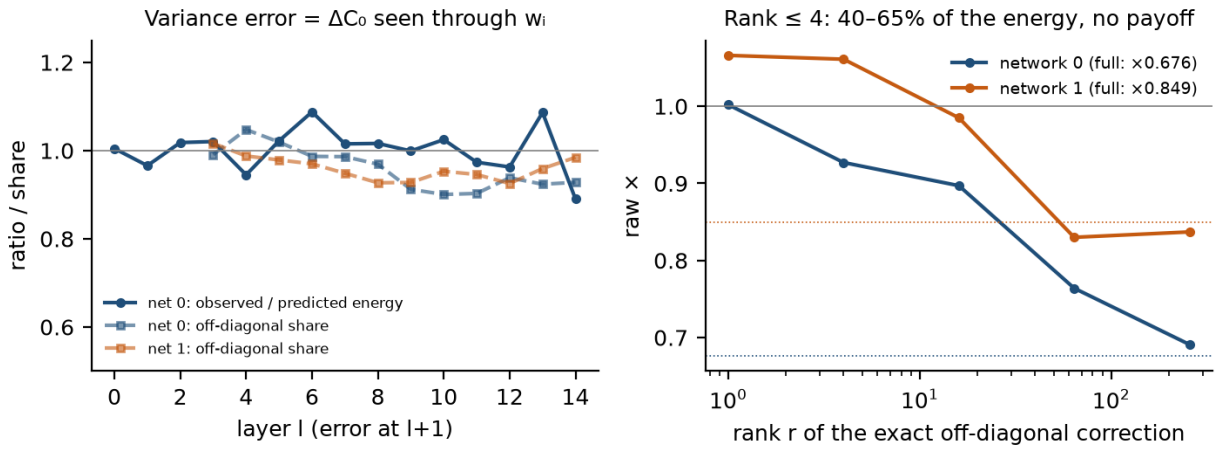


Figure 5. Left: the identity of §6.4 on real matrices — observed off-diagonal energy of the next layer's variance error over its prediction $(8/n)\|\Delta C_0\|^2_F$ (network 0, one oracle seed, every layer), and the off-diagonal share of that error's noise-subtracted energy (both networks, two seeds; layers 0–2 are below the oracle's noise floor). Right: the payoff (raw error ×, oracle substitution at layers 5, 8, 11, 14) of the best rank-r part of the exact off-diagonal correction; dotted lines are the full correction. The two dominant directions carry 40–65% of the energy and nothing of the payoff.

Consequence 4: the step's pair inputs are wrong, but only worth fixing together. The covariance error that the step gives birth to (22–30% of ΔC_0 at depth; with *every* input exact the step itself is accurate to ~0.1%) comes from the step's own inputs, and we checked the two n×n ones against oracles [M]. The κ_3 (2,1) slice D, carried by the source representation, is 7% wrong on the entries the chain computes (correlation 0.997, no level error) and makes 73–78% of the born error; exact D at just two layers is worth ×0.885 / ×0.931 on two networks. But **any part of it alone is a coin toss**: the computed block alone is ×0.900 on one network and ×1.027 on the other. The closure's κ_4 (2,2) slice K22 is 20% wrong (correlation 0.62–0.70); pair features predict the true K22 out of sample better than the closure (R^2 0.45–0.61 against 0.35–0.45), and the exact K22 at two layers is ×0.970 on one network and ×1.102 on the other. About 85% of D's error survives every tunable approximation of the representation; it is the k = 3 truncation of the births. The chain's errors form a compensating set, and a correction of one member, exact or learned, can push the rest out of balance. That is §3.5's consistency principle seen from the other side: what made removing terms on both sides *gain* accuracy is what makes fixing one input alone *lose* it.

> **Proposition 2 (parity).** The chain's error in the next layer's κ_3 diagonal of neuron i is the cubic projection Σ_{abc} W_ai W_bi W_ci $\Delta\kappa_3$(l)_abc of the post-activation κ_3 error through the same independent weights. Conditioned on $\Delta\kappa_3$ it has mean zero for every neuron, and the errors are independent across neurons. [D]
>
> *Proof.* As in Proposition 1, $\Delta\kappa_3$(l) is independent of `W(l+1)`; a cubic form in a zero-mean Gaussian vector has zero mean because every odd moment of w_i vanishes, whatever the coefficient tensor; independence across i follows from the independence of the columns. ∎

So where the variance error inherits a coherent level from tr ΔC, the κ_3 error has none, and its mean over neurons should be zero up to its own standard error. *Measured.* Against the per-neuron 10^7-sample moment oracles of two networks, z = mean/standard error of the κ_3-diagonal error has mean z^2 = 0.93 and max |z| = 2.29 over 28 (layer, network) pairs, exactly zero-mean noise, while the variance error sits 3–9 standard errors from zero at every layer ≥ 8 [M]. The mean is the first-order case, and the output shows it: the coherent (per-network mean) part of the final-layer error is 0.46% of its MSE, and the residuals of two consecutive layers correlate at 0.004 (each random W scrambles the error vector), so no post-hoc correction of the output has anything to learn either (N64; 504aldo's row 10 found the

same) [M]. A per-neuron feature can see the κ_3 error only through the forms the identity allows: a cubic form against the chain's own κ_3 (its t, 21–30% of the error's signal at the last layer) and a linear one against the partial trace $m_a = \Sigma_b \Delta\kappa_{3}_abb$ (the pre-activation mean, 9–17%); ≈40% together at depth [M]; and N70 showed that removing the visible part of the moment errors buys nothing. Everything else needs the joint object: n^2 numbers for the variance, n^3 for κ_3. That is §6.2's wall again, seen from the accuracy side. The chain is also very sensitive to that object: off-diagonal noise at the level of a $2{\cdot}10^7$-sample estimate, added at every layer, costs ×3.2–3.9 [M], one more reason no sampling hybrid of this chain can work at this budget.

Measured, random directions. The sharper test of both propositions is to read the same post-activations along directions that have nothing to do with the network. We replaced W_l by a matrix of i.i.d. N(0, 2/n) entries, read the chain's variance and κ_3 along its columns, and estimated the same projections by Monte Carlo (10^7 samples, two seeds, the same samples for the real columns; networks 0 and 1, layers 4, 8, 11, 14). If the per-neuron errors are projections through independent columns, the real columns' errors must be distributed as the random directions' are, and they are: for κ_3 both means are zero ($|z| \le 2.0$, the two means within 1.7 standard errors of each other) and the noise-subtracted spreads agree to 0.96–1.12 over the eight layer–network pairs; for the variance both carry the same coherent level (the means within 1.6 standard errors) and the spreads agree to 0.98–1.03 at layers 8–14 of both networks (layer 4's variance error is below the oracle's noise floor); the standardised 1st and 99th percentiles agree within 0.1–0.4 on heavy-tailed distributions on both sides. The per-neuron errors are i.i.d. draws from the law of the chain's error along a random direction, with that law's variance — not only without a coherent level [M] (`experiments/2026-10-07_randdir`).

When can a per-neuron correction work? The truncation order decides, not the depth. Proposition 1 says a model of a neuron's error from that neuron's own state sees the coherent level and whatever is a function of the state. For our chain that is nothing. For a Gaussian closure it is most of the error, and Proposition 3 says why: the closure drops κ_3, and a neuron's true κ_3 is almost a function of its own mean ($\mathrm{corr}(\kappa_{3i}, \mu_i) = +0.87 \ldots +0.93$ against Monte-Carlo at the last layer of every shape below, 79–88% of its variance explained by (μ, σ)), because both are projections through the same weight column and $v \mathbin{/\!/} m$. We measured the learnable share, leave one network out, for ARC's SIMPLE k = 2 and k = 3 on the same networks [M]:

shape	L/n	k = 2: learnable share	k = 2: coherent share	k = 3: learnable share	k = 3: coherent share
1024 × 16 (ten public networks, 10^9 truth)	1/64	**66%**	26%	0.0%	0.3%
512 × 16 (6 networks)	1/32	**66%**	28%	4.1%	1.2%
256 × 8 / 16 / 32 (10 each)	1/32 … 1/8	**64–66%**	26–35%	1.4–3.4%	0.9–3.0%

The share does not grow with depth; it is a property of what the estimator carries. A function of $\alpha = \mu/\sigma$ alone carries most of the Gaussian closure's learnable part (α: 56%, a cubic in α: 65% at 1024 × 16); the readout patterns of a missing κ_3 or κ_4 level alone carry no more than the intercept. Across all shapes the odd orders keep no level (coherent share of the pre-activation mean and κ_3 errors ≤ 0.7%), the variance's level grows with depth (to 19–30% at 256 × 32). This also settles a question we had misread: the learned corrector that worked in Phase 1 (mliston, forum 18170, raw MSE −17 to −19% on 20 networks) took as input, besides the chain's moments, the shape statistics of a Monte-Carlo cloud, which carry joint information; it is consistent with Proposition 1 and needs no depth argument (`experiments/2026-10-13_coherence-law`).

The learnable part has a closed form. A neuron's true pre-activation κ_3 is proportional to its mean, $\kappa_{3_i} \approx c(l)\cdot\mu_i$, with zero intercept and R^2 rising from 0.5 at layer 1 (the first layer whose pre-activations are not Gaussian) to 0.71–0.90 deeper, at every shape [M]. The first-layer slope can be computed. Expanding the joint cumulants of the layer-0 activations in their correlations ρ (Mehler's formula), the diagonal terms give 9.82/n, the ρ^2 terms add 4.09/n through $E\,\rho^2 = 1/n$, and the rest is uncorrelated with μ, so for He weights $c(1)\cdot n = 12(\kappa_3(R) + B_2)/E[R] = 13.91$, with R the ReLU of a unit Gaussian and $B_2 = \phi(0)/2 - \phi(0)^3$ [D]. We measure 13.94 ± 0.14 (standard error) on twenty 1024 × 16 networks, 13.98 at width 512 and 14.2 at 256 [M]. Deeper, the slope decays to 0.5–0.8 of c(1) and stays a property of the shape (a few per cent of spread across networks at 1024 × 16). The same argument makes the (2,1) slice nearly rank one, $D_{ij} \approx t_j/3$ (correlation 0.81 inside our chain at 1024 × 16). We put this law into the chain in place of its κ_3: $t = a + c\mu$ with constants averaged over other networks of the shape, $D = 1\cdot t^T/3$, no κ_3 state, $O(n^2)$ per layer. The reference is $\kappa_3 = 0$, whose error is 1–12% below that of ARC's k = 2 at every shape [M]:

shape	L/n	$\kappa_3 = 0$	skew-law closure	k = 3 chain	share of k = 3's gain kept	learnable in the closure's residual
1024 × 16	1/64	4.1e-6	1.44e-6	3.9e-8	64% (10/10 networks)	0.2%
512 × 16	1/32	1.6e-5	6.0e-6	3.5e-7	63% (6/6)	–1.8%
256 × 8	1/32	3.5e-5	1.2e-5	9.3e-7	65% (10/10)	1.7%
256 × 16	1/16	6.5e-5	3.6e-5	2.8e-6	35% (9/10)	1.3%
256 × 32	1/8	1.2e-4	1.7e-4	1.4e-5	worse than $\kappa_3 = 0$ (3/10)	—

At L/n ≤ 1/32 the law removes 63–65% of the Gaussian closure's error on all 26 networks, the share the per-neuron model learned, and what it leaves has nothing learnable in it (–2 … +2%). The learnable two thirds of a Gaussian closure's error is this law. The remainder is the incoherent part of Proposition 1, and it carries the score: our k = 3 chain is still ×37 more accurate than the closure at 1024 × 16. The law also has a range. At L/n = 1/16 it keeps 35% of the gain with a wide spread across networks; at 1/8 it is worse than $\kappa_3 = 0$, even with each network's own constants; and the diagonal alone (D = 0) is worse than $\kappa_3 = 0$ at four of the five shapes. An approximate κ_3 that the rest of the chain does not match compounds layer by layer, the consistency rule of §3.5 again (`experiments/2026-10-14_skew`).

Why the skew follows the mean. With the next column w i.i.d. N(0, q/n) and independent of the layer, Isserlis gives the slope of the next κ_3 on the next mean over the neurons exactly in expectation, $c(l+1) = (3q/n)\cdot\langle v, m\rangle/\|m\|^2$, with $R^2 = \cos^2(v, m)\cdot q_v/(1 + q_v)$ with $q_v = 9\|v\|^2/(6\|G\|^2)$ of Proposition 3, and $D' \approx t'/3$ (one pairing instead of three), where $v_a = \Sigma_b\, \kappa_3(h_a, h_b, h_b) = \mathrm{Cov}(h_a, \|h - m\|^2)$ is the post-activation partial trace [D]. On Monte-Carlo truth the predicted slope matches the measured one at every layer to a median 0.6–1.6% at 1024 × 16 and 2.4–4.6% at widths 256–512 [M]. The first-layer value splits into 9.82 from the projected per-neuron skews and $4.09 = 6(1 - 1/\pi)$ from the input's radius, which a positively homogeneous network passes on as an exact scale mode: inputs on the sphere give 9.68 and 9.24, and the Gaussian–sphere difference equals $3\bar{\sigma}^2_w$ (the μ^2-weighted mean variance) at every layer to within 0.024 [D, M]. The rest of the alignment is made inside the network. An amplitude mode along the mean takes over the post-activation covariance with depth (the mean's Rayleigh quotient grows from 1.2 to 101 times the mean variance), v is the neurons' response to it (cosine 0.93–0.99), and a ReLU neuron's response to a common rescaling is exactly its mean by Euler's theorem; together

cos(v, m) = 0.92 → 0.99 [M] (`experiments/2026-10-14_vm`). Projecting the chain's κ_3 on its partial trace alone (t = 3v/n, $D_{ab} = v_b/n$) keeps 72–73% of the k = 3 gain at L/n ≤ 1/32 but only 28% of its log gain at 1024 × 16: about 72% of what carrying κ_3 buys in log terms lives in the all-distinct part of Proposition 3. Positive homogeneity is what the law needs: with leaky ReLU the radius test and the alignment behave as with ReLU, while with SiLU Proposition 5 still holds (median deviation 4.5%) but cos(v, m) falls to 0.75 and the law's R^2 to 0.47 at layer 15 (256 × 16) [M]. Two write-ups posted on 2026-10-15, after these measurements (repository history 2026-10-14) and before our release, reach related results independently: il.miscusi (forum 18248) uses the same scale mode (covariance + εmm^T, $\kappa_3 + 2\varepsilon \cdot \mathrm{Sym}(C \otimes m)$, $\kappa_4 + 4\varepsilon \cdot \mathrm{Pair}_3(C \otimes C)$) and removes it inside an estimator; kai_leal_gonzalez (forum 18246) states a conditional form of the decomposition behind the slope identity (the next κ_3 given the weight column's projection on the mean).

The same measurement can be run on any estimator from its outputs alone, because the pre-activation mean is linear: its truth is W^T times the true means of the previous layer. `scripts/error_anatomy.py` does that on the ten public networks with their 10^9-sample truth. On the starter kit's covariance-propagation example it finds a final error 26% coherent and 66% learnable out of sample, with the order-one parity holding ($z^2 = 0.98$ over 150 layer–network pairs); on our designated estimator, 0.6% coherent and nothing learnable ($z^2 = 1.11$) [M].

6.5 The instrument has a resolution, and it is coarser than most of our levers

One more boundary, of a different kind. Under the Phase-2 grader the ranked number is a mean over **50** held-out MLPs, with a further 50 sealed. Two scalar levels of our own method, re-tuned on 10 of our baked MLPs, gave in sequence [M]:

stage	value
10 baked MLPs, float64 research chain	**×1.0089**, better on 9/10
100 baked MLPs, the production estimator	×1.0030, better on **66/100**
the grader (332872 vs 332403)	**×0.9987, worse**

The local gain was real and still reversed sign on a different draw of networks. We take the observed discrepancy, **≈0.4–0.5%**, as the instrument's resolution: **a fitted lever worth less than about 2–3% cannot be validated by a submission.** The converse also held, and it is the reason the rest of our numbers can be trusted: levers that are *structural* (a term added or removed by a derivation, a cut matched on both sides, an exact arithmetic saving that moves the output only by float rounding) transfer, and the last ten ports, each validated on our 100 public networks before shipping, landed on their local projections to the printed digit (k3o projected 5.12 → graded 5.1127e-9, …, k3z 3.735 → 3.7357e-9) [M]. The one learned component (§3.7) was validated the honest way: trained on 10 networks, measured on 87 others it had never seen (×0.988), then graded (×0.988); its coefficients were never fitted to leaderboard feedback.

7. One order up: where the missing accuracy is, and what it costs in this representation

The last thing we measured asks where the leaders' accuracy comes from. Wu et al.'s error law is $c_K(L/n)^K$, and our own ladder at 1024×16 follows it: k = 1, 2, 3 give 3.3e-4, 4.5e-6 and 4.1e-8. At small width, where ARC's k_max = 4 (the full fourth cumulant, carried factorised) is affordable, we ran the reference ladder and our chain against Monte-Carlo ground truth at 10^7 samples (Figure 7, left) [M]:

final-layer MSE	ARC k = 3	our chain	ARC k = 3 augmented	ARC k = 4
n = 128, L = 8	9.4e-6	3.18e-6	4.5e-6	1.10e-6 (×0.34 of ours)
n = 256, L = 8	8.0e-7	3.55e-7	3.58e-7	≈4.7e-8 (×0.13–0.17)

Our chain sits at the level of the augmented k = 3 at both widths, as at 1024×16. In the reference, k = 3 augmented and k = 4 sum the same Edgeworth diagrams; the only difference is that k = 4 carries the fourth cumulant completely, and that alone is ×3 at L/n = 1/16 and ×6–7 at 1/32. Exact k = 4 costs $\approx L^2 n^4$, far outside the budget at 1024×16, so we took its gain apart with the chain as the instrument: k = 4's per-layer statistics substituted into our chain upstream of its last step, then k = 4's κ_4 split by where and how it was born (a full factorial over channels on 8 networks at each of n = 128 and n = 256; the age and tree splits on 3) [M].

7.1 Which statistics, which age, which births

- **Which statistics.** Over the 2^8 subsets of the eight per-layer channels our step reads, the core is the κ_4 diagonal together with its (3,1) slice: ×0.64 at n = 256 and ×0.60 at n = 128 for the pair, the strongest synergy of all 28 pairs. The covariance and the (2,2) slice follow by themselves (dropping them from the full set costs nothing); each channel alone is worth little. That is §3.5's consistency principle one order up.
- **Which age.** ARC appends the κ_4 born at each ReLU as its own block of factors, so a block's age is known. Our closure explains only 48–73% of k = 4's κ_4 diagonal, and what it misses sits in the blocks born in the last two layers: those blocks exact, plus the closure for everything older, recover the whole gain of the exact fourth cumulant (n = 256: ×0.61 / 0.47 / 0.60 against ×0.60 / 0.43 / 0.54 for all of k = 4). The closure set to k = 4's own level, without the young pattern, is worse than ours.
- **Which births.** The young κ_4 is a set of trees on the step's covariance C (Figure 6): the path $12 \cdot d_1 C\ d_2 C\ d_2 C\ d_1$, the star $4 \cdot d_1 C\ d_3\ (C\ d_1)^2$, and the graph in which the whole third cumulant is handed on through one covariance edge,

> $\kappa_4 \text{post}(i, j, k, l) \supset 12 \cdot d_1(i)\ C(i, j)\ d_2(j)\ \kappa_3 \text{pre}(j, k, l)\ d_1(k)\ d_1(l)$ ("3+2") [D]

obtained by expanding y = ReLU(z) to second order in δz around the mean, taking the fourth joint cumulant with Leonov–Shiryaev, and keeping the terms linear in $\kappa_3$pre (checked against ARC's tree blocks to 1e-16). Switching the trees on one at a time in ARC's own step: without the 3+2 graph the young κ_4 is worse than none; the paths matter, the stars less; the repeated-index block, where the self-variance transfer $\kappa_4(a,a,b,c) \mathrel{+}= 2 \cdot \text{var_a}\ d_1 d_2\ d_1 d_1\ \kappa_3(a,b,c)$ lives, is secondary. That is why the κ_4 carriers we had built first, all of which carried that transfer and not the 3+2 graph, moved the final error by ×0.87–1.11, differently on different networks.

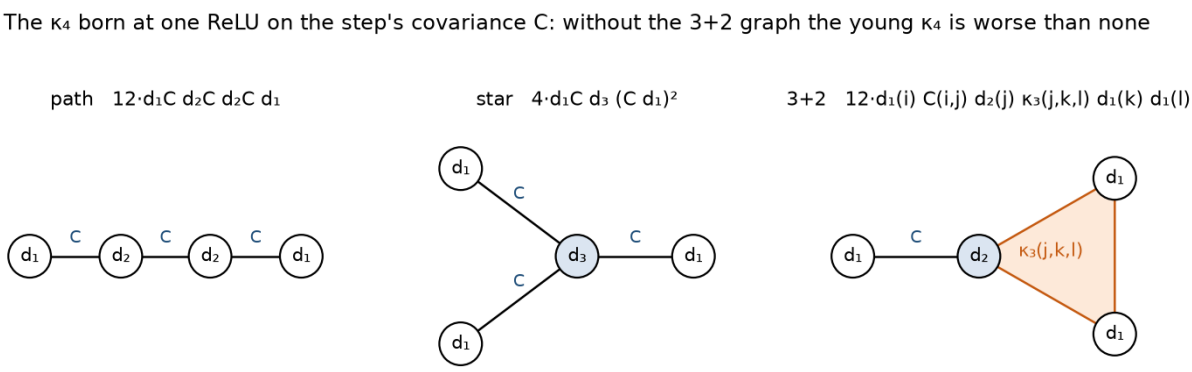


Figure 6. The three κ_4 trees born at one ReLU on the step's covariance C, with the Wick gate at each node ($d_k = E[\mathrm{ReLU}^{(k)}(z)]$ under the Gaussian closure). The 3+2 graph hands the whole third cumulant of the pre-activations, all-distinct part included, to the fourth cumulant of the post-activations through one covariance edge; it is then inherited through the next layers' weights.

A one-line reading of the 3+2 graph, which we offer as interpretation [U]: the fourth cumulant that matters is the third cumulant one ReLU later. The chain already carries κ_3 in full for its own readout; what the next order adds is the same object, gated once more and read into κ_4.

7.2 A reader of the young trees from the chain's own state

We built the young trees from what the chain already holds — its covariance, its Wick gates and its κ_3 sources — carried them for two layers on dense legs, and read them into the κ_4 diagonal and the (3,1) slice, adding only the part beyond the closure's pattern so that the closure keeps its own level. The tree construction reproduces ARC's tree blocks to 1e-16, and the leg implementation the factorised one to 1e-14 [M]:

× of our chain's final-layer MSE	**n = 256, L = 8 (4 networks)**	**1024 × 16 (10 networks)**
young trees → κ_4 diagonal + (3,1) slice	×0.62–0.67 on three, ×0.94 on the fourth	**×0.701 (better on 10/10; 0.62–0.78)**
… κ_4 diagonal only	×0.72–0.76, ×1.01	×0.824 (10/10)
… trees born in the last layer only	×0.71–0.80, ×0.98	×0.815 (10/10)
… with the band basis of §3.6 in the chain	—	×0.72 (3 networks)

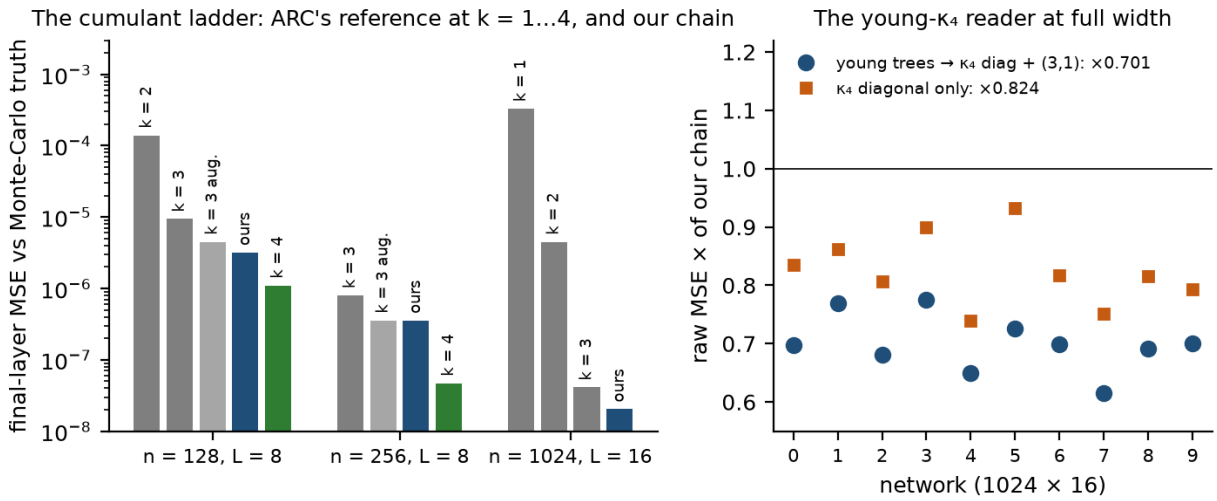


Figure 7. Left: the cumulant ladder against Monte-Carlo truth. At small width ARC's k = 4 is ×3 (n = 128) to ×6–7 (n = 256) better than our chain, which sits at the augmented k = 3's level; at 1024 × 16 the reference's own k = 1, 2, 3 and our designated estimator. Right: the young-tree reader at full width, per network — the first κ_4 carrier in this work that improves every network.

This is the first κ_4 carrier in this work that improves every network, and ×0.70 of our raw error is close to the leaders' raw error (1.15–1.35e-8 for the first four on 2026-10-16, against our 2.03e-8). Read against that board, raw 1.42e-8 would score 2.6e-9 at our utilisation (≈ 22nd place), 2.0e-9 at 14% (≈ 10th) and 1.42e-9 at the 10% floor, level with the leading entry [D]. The accuracy for the top of the board is in this chain; the cost of carrying κ_3 (§6.1–§6.2) is what stands between the two.

7.3 The same, inside ARC's own algorithm

If the gain lives in young κ_4, ARC's factored k = 4 should not need its old κ_4 blocks either. It appends 2n factor columns per ReLU, so its κ_4 work grows like L^2. We ran it with the blocks older than a layers removed after every linear step, either dropped or replaced by one scale-mixture block v $(C \otimes C)_{sym}$ whose level v is fitted on the dropped blocks' diagonal, O(n r) (the stepped run reproduces `mlp_kprop` to 1.6e-16; nothing dropped reproduces it exactly) [M]:

share of k = 4's gain over k = 3 kept	128 × 8 (8 nets)	256 × 8 (3)	256 × 16 (3)
blocks of age ≤ 2, the rest dropped	78%	43%	1%
age ≤ 1 + one scale-mixture block	85%	89%	63%
age ≤ 2 + one scale-mixture block	92%	95%	78%
age ≤ 3 + one scale-mixture block	97%	98%	**89%**, at 0.40 of the κ_4 columns and 0.61 of the wall time

Dropping old κ_4 fails inside ARC's algorithm, because nothing else carries its level (in our chain the closure did); one scale-mixture block restores it. The age that keeps about 90% grows slowly with depth, and the wall-time saving is smaller than the column saving, because most of ARC's k = 4 step, which costs 66–207 times k = 3's wall time here, is not its κ_4 columns. For ARC this is a practical knob, not a cheap k = 4 (`experiments/2026-10-14_k4age`).

7.4 Why it is not in the designated submission

The readers are dense products over the hubs of the young generations [M]. The cheap ones, the path with coinciding hubs and the star, are $O(n^2)$ and alone they are worse than nothing (×1.05). The one that matters, the 3+2 graph, needs the cross-layer pairing $Dx(a, r) = \kappa_3(z_r$ at birth; z_a, z_a now). We found it inside the D pairing the chain already computes: pair with the single legs as they were before their transport, then recover $D = Dx \cdot W$ with one product per age. Metered in the shipped estimator with exact-shape stubs: +0.22% of the FLOPs per product, plus the pairing the last layer then needs (+4.27% per age), which cannot be dropped — the last layer's 3+2 pays only together with the upstream ones, and alone it is worse than none. The best variant, the 3+2 of the youngest generation, is ×0.905 raw on 10/10 networks at +7.40% metered FLOPs and projects to ×0.972 in score (3.63e-9); the two-generation variant to ×0.973; the full reader, ×0.70 raw, costs more than it buys. All of them fall below the bar we had set in advance for a port (metered FLOPs ≤ +10% and a projection under 3.55e-9), so none is shipped.

One variant had stayed unpriced: the readers of the two youngest generations without the last layer's pairing, which the meter put at +6.25% (3.49e-9). We ported it after the bar was set, to measure it where it counts (`experiments/2026-10-06_k4a`). The port is correct: its D equals the shipped estimator's to 5e-6 with the readers off, and the readers reproduce the research chain network by network once their projection coefficient is taken over the rows production computes. On the 100 public networks it is ×0.924 raw (better on 95) at +5.1% FLOPs: 3.63e-9 projected, the same step the metered variants gave. What the meter does not see is the call count. The restructured pairing adds four small dense products per layer, 5,581 flopscope calls per network (+23%), and on the grader the residual time rose from 0.310 s to 0.393 s per network (medians over the 100 public networks) against the 0.400 s cap: 16 of 100 networks crossed it (0.401–0.479 s) and were zeroed (submission 334486, a probe, not designated). A construction is priced in calls as well as in FLOPs; at about 120 calls per Strassen product, the headroom under the cap is ten products per network, not four per layer: §6.1's mechanism, one level down.

The leaders reach ×0.57–0.67 of our raw error at 0.61–0.68 of our FLOPs (the first four on 2026-10-16). If these trees are what they carry, the difference between us is a cheaper base, and §6.1–§6.2 are about the κ_3 state we did not find a cheaper form of [U].

8. Limitations, and what we would do next

The gap to the top of the board is real; we know where their accuracy is (§7), not how they pay for it. On 2026-10-16, the day before the close, the first four teams score 1.4–1.6e-9 with raw error 1.15–1.35e-8 at 11–12.5% utilisation: ×1.5–1.8 more accurate *and* ×1.5–1.6 cheaper than our 2.03e-8 at 18.3%; we are 55th of 295 ranked teams, down from 33rd of 266 on 2026-10-05 at the same score, as most of the first fifty teams improved in those eleven days. The per-network errors of the 2026-10-05 leaders correlate 0.69–0.76 with ours and the ratio is nearly constant (CV 8–9%): they are better everywhere rather than on a class of networks [M]. Their public telemetry showed the same wall time as ours for 0.6–0.8 of our FLOPs, two of them at the residual-time cap, and three loading data in `setup()` [M]. Their methods are not published. Everything else in this section is our reading, marked [U].

What this representation can reach with compute free. Three levers were only ever refused on cost: path births from sources of every age, thin correction legs of rank 384 instead of 24, and the $\kappa_4 \to \kappa_3$ coupling at half strength. On today's base (the float64 research chain with the matched cut, E2 and marg2; without the band basis and the learned corrector; 10 networks) they are worth ×0.959, ×0.980 and ×0.970 alone and **×0.921 stacked**, better on 9 of 10 networks [M]. Carried over to the designated

submission's graded raw error, that is raw ≈ 1.87e-8 [U: the transfer is a projection]: with compute free this representation would still be ×1.4–1.6 less accurate than the first four teams, and even at the 10% floor, which it is nowhere near, it would score ≈1.9e-9, behind their 1.4–1.6e-9. Our earlier estimate of this ceiling (raw 1.72e-8, 2026-09-28) stacked levers measured on an older base, including a deeper κ_4 birth and two fitted scalars that we did not re-measure here; fitted scalars are known to arrive at a third of their strength (§6.5).

What we would try next, and why we did not. [U]

- *The young fourth cumulant, cheaper.* §7 finds the accuracy and prices it: the readers are dense products over the hubs of the two youngest generations. A basis that rides the transport for the young hubs (§3.6's band, applied to the trees instead of the old κ_3 sources), or reading the trees' effect on the next layer's covariance without materialising the (3,1) slice are where we would look first.
- *A κ_3 state that is not a list of sources.* §6.2 rules out closing κ_3 on the slices the step reads; §6.1 rules out compressing the source list by any construction we could price. A different *state*, rather than a cheaper encoding of the same one, is the only door left on the cost side, and the leaders' telemetry says one exists.
- *Joint corrections from joint information.* §6.4 says per-neuron and partial corrections are blind or unstable; the oracle says joint exactness is worth ×0.2–0.3. Anything that captures the pair-level structure of the error at $O(n^2)$ per layer would be worth a great deal; every $O(n^2)$ predictor we measured explains ≤6–10% of it out of sample.

9. Use of language models

This project was carried out by one participant, Artyom Kuznetsov, working with **Claude Code** (Anthropic's Claude models: Opus 5.5 for most of the work, and Fable 5.1 from 2026-10-05 to 2026-10-07 for the write-up revision, the last two measurements (§7.4's grader probe, §6.4's random-direction test) and the release dry run) on a laptop and in Claude Code cloud sessions.

- **Division of labour.** The research was led by the participant: the problem, the goals, the direction at every fork, the choice of which ideas to pursue and which results to accept, and every submission were the participant's decisions, and the key ideas of the method came out of that direction. Claude Code, under the participant's direction, wrote all of the code (the production estimators, the float64 research chain and its switches, the Monte-Carlo oracles, every analysis script), ran the experiments and the pre-submission checklists, kept the research journal (released with the code), proposed derivations and measurements as the work went, each checked numerically before it was used, and drafted this document.
- **How the output was verified.** No number in this document is taken from a model's statement: each comes from a logged run, every switch reproduces its predecessor bitwise when off, every measurement harness was first gated on a number it had to reproduce, and every graded claim is readable from the public submission pages. Interpretations that an intervention has not isolated are marked [U]. The analysis added in the last week (§6.2's check on the true tensor, §6.4's skew law and its propositions) was also audited by separate Claude Code instances that re-derived the formulas and re-read every number against the logs, read-only; the corrections they found are listed in the journal.
- **Errors we know the model made**, kept because they are informative: three strategic claims stronger than their evidence on a single day (a cost-model extrapolation presented as an estimate, an upper bound presented as an expected gain, and a secondary-source paraphrase of the judging criteria that would have redirected two weeks of work), all caught before they cost a

submission; and three shipping defects caught only by the grader (a small-width bug that the contract check would have found, an unused `import numpy` that made the grader reject a submission, and a buffer sized for the graded shape alone, which failed the grader's smoke test on a probe submission because that test runs another shape). Each produced a written rule that the rest of the project followed.

10. Reproducibility

- **Code.** The designated submission's estimator is a single file (`estimator_k3z.py`, the same bytes as in the submission archive of 333534); it imports only flopscope, whestbench and the Python standard library and loads no data in `setup()`. The κ_4 corrector's 118 coefficients are plain lists in that file; the script that trained them and the oracles it trained on are in the repository.
- **Seeds.** The only randomness inside `predict()` is the range finder of the thin correction legs, seeded by `mlp.seed` (rules §5.5). Monte-Carlo oracles use fixed, recorded seeds.
- **Every number** in §2–§8 points to a logged run in the repository: `experiments/<date>_<topic>/RESULTS.md`, with the scripts and the small outputs beside it. The public repository keeps this layout because the scripts find each other by relative paths; `scripts/setup.sh` builds the environments at the pinned versions and `scripts/fetch_baked.py` rebuilds the public networks we measured on. The catalogue of negative results is `notes/NEGATIVE-RESULTS.md` (N1–N76).
- **Check it yourself.** Where each headline claim lives, what to run, and what it costs on a laptop CPU (folders are under `experiments/`; "oracle" means a 10^7-sample Monte-Carlo estimate that the folder's own script regenerates):

claim	folder	entry point	cost to rerun
graded scores, wall and residual times (§5.1, A.2)	the public Alcrowd submission pages	`scripts/poll_sub.py <id>`	seconds
the designated estimator on the 100 public networks (§5.1)	`src/estimator_k3z.py`	`whest run` (README)	≈65 min
the ablation on 32 networks (§5.2)	`2026-10-03_evidence`	`run_arm.sh <arm>`	≈20 min per arm
where the error is born (§2, Figure 1)	`2026-09-30_tail-accuracy`	`t1_attrib.py inject R`	not recorded
Proposition 1, 95% off-diagonal (§6.4, Figure 5)	`2026-10-02_cov-error`	`cov_oracle.py`, `theory_check.py`, `t2.py split`	≈35 min per oracle
Proposition 2, parity (§6.4)	`2026-10-02_parity`	`parity.py <net>`	1.5 min, plus two ≈18 min oracles
random directions (§6.4)	`2026-10-07_randdir`	`run_mc.sh`, `run_chain.sh <net>`	≈30 min per network

claim	folder	entry point	cost to rerun
(t, D) is not a sufficient κ_3 state (§6.2)	`2026-09-28_state-closure`	`closure.py`, `tdchain.py`, `fitclose.py`	not recorded
Proposition 3, the share derived (§6.2)	`2026-10-13_prop3`	`prop3.py <n> 16 <nets>`	seconds at n = 128, ≈ 20 s per network at 256
what a per-neuron correction can learn, k = 2 vs k = 3 (§6.4)	`2026-10-13_coherence-law`	`coh.py`, `coh_k2.py`, `coh_analyze.py`	≈ 1 h for all five shapes
the skew law and its closure: c(1)·n = 13.91, learnable part removed (§6.4)	`2026-10-14_skew`	`skew_law.py`, `skew_chain.py baked`, `skew_cs.py <tag>` + `coh_analyze.py --est cs`	≈ 15 min in all
why the skew follows the mean: slope = partial trace's projection, input radius, amplitude mode (§6.4)	`2026-10-14_vm`	`vm_mc.py <net> <gauss/sphere> 2e6 1`, `vm_analyze.py`	≈ 7 min per 1024 × 16 run
the error anatomy of any estimator (§6.4)	`scripts/error_anatomy.py`	`error_anatomy.py <estimator.py>`	≈ 40 s per network
the construction costs what it saves (§6.1)	N54 `2026-09-25_cost`, N55 `2026-09-26_k3m-port`, N58 `2026-09-26_old-tail`, N59 `2026-09-28_tail-sampling`, N76 `2026-10-04_r4`	each folder's `RESULTS.md`	—
the cost map (§4.1)	`2026-10-02_costmap`	`instrument.py k3z`, `check_prof.py k3z`	one network, ≈1 min
the cumulant ladder and k = 4 taken apart (§7, Figure 7)	`2026-10-03_korder`	`korder.py`, `subst.py`	not recorded
the young-κ_4 reader at full width (§7.2)	`2026-10-04_r2`, `2026-10-04_r3`	`r2young.py`, `r3full.py`	≈15 s per network and arm
the age-truncated k = 4 in ARC's algorithm (§7.3)	`2026-10-14_k4age`	`gate.py`, then `k4age.py <n> <L> 0 <nets>`	≈ 12 min per network at 256 × 16

claim	folder	entry point	cost to rerun
the port measured on the grader (§7.4)	`2026-10-06_k4a`	`RESULTS.md` §6–§7; submission 334486	—

- **Release.** Every production estimator, the float64 research chain, the scripts and logged results of every measurement cited here, and the research journal are released under the MIT licence in a public repository when Phase 2 closes (17 October 2026), together with the Monte-Carlo oracles under CC BY 4.0; the links are posted in the forum thread of this write-up. The competition's own rules (§6) would require the code only for a place prize.

Appendix A. Engineering: exact arithmetic, and the budgets that are not the meter

This appendix holds the parts of the work that are engineering rather than understanding. We moved them out of the main text because the judging guidelines say performance optimisation is of less interest; we keep them because about a fifth of the score gain since k3m came from here (k3t, k3w, k3x, k3y and k3z together ×0.931 of the ×0.693 from 5.39e-9 to 3.74e-9), and because the three caps in A.2 decided the depth of every design choice.

A.1 Exact arithmetic: fewer billed FLOPs, the same numbers

Each item below changes the FLOP bill and moves the output only by float rounding (≤ 1.2e-6 relative); each passed a bitwise gate against its predecessor with the switch off, and each landed on the grader as projected [M].

- **Strassen's recursion in flopscope operations** (permitted with no level limit, as the sponsor confirmed on the forum on 2026-09-11), batched over sources with preallocated per-level workspaces so that the number of calls does not grow ×7 per level. The D pairings need only $\Sigma_k L_k R_k^T$, and Strassen is bilinear, so the K leaf products are summed before the recombination, which runs once (level 4, k3h: util 32.4% → 28.9%, MSE unchanged).
- **Level 5 only where it pays for its wall.** Level 5 everywhere would bill ×0.939 but doubles the wall time (A.2). Measuring each contraction's FLOPs saved per second of wall added (leg transport 0.49 %/s, the C and path-leg transport 0.46, C_pre 0.39, the band members 0.26, the D pairing 0.27) and deepening those five recovered most of it inside the 120 s cap (k3t, k3w, k3x; grader wall max 95.2 s).
- **$C_{pre} = W^T(CW)$ is symmetric**: compute the upper block row and the lower-right block, copy the remaining block as a transpose — 3/4 of the product, ×0.9934 of the FLOPs at no wall cost.
- **The band entry's triangular solves.** flopscope bills `solve` as LU + back-substitution even when the matrix is triangular; one explicit R^{-1} per entry, applied to the entrant by Strassen, bills ×0.9941 and is numerically clean on all 100 public networks even though R's condition number reaches $7 \cdot 10^4$ in float32 (k3y, graded 3.7573e-9).
- **Winograd's form, and the last half products.** Winograd's variant of the recursion needs 15 matrix additions per level instead of 18, and the two half products of the symmetric C_pre also run at level 5: ×0.9940 of the FLOPs together, wall-neutral (grader wall median 91.2 s against k3y's 92.2 s; k3z, graded 3.7357e-9).

A.2 The budgets that are not the meter

Three caps zero a network's prediction when crossed, and in practice they, not the FLOP count, set the depth of every engineering choice: **400 ms of non-flopscope ("residual") time**, **120 s of wall time**, and **8 GB of memory**.

- Residual time is ≈20–40 μs per flopscope call regardless of the array size, so it caps the number of operations: the shipped estimator makes ≈24 000 calls per network and reads 0.31 s (median) / 0.33 s (max) on the grader's own telemetry, ≈0.73× our quiet local runner. Every batched design choice in §3.1 exists for this cap.
- Wall time caps the Strassen depth. One more level everywhere bills ×0.939 and doubles the wall (×2.2, ≈140 s projected against the 120 s cap) at a peak RSS of 7.21 GB of 8 GB; a 32×32 leaf has no BLAS efficiency left. The level-5 sites run at 8–14 billed GFLOP/s against 17–30 for level-4 and element-wise work: deeper recursion buys FLOPs with wall time. Five level-5 sites chosen by FLOPs saved per second of wall leave the grader at **98.8 s max / 91.2 s median**; the next site measured 0.094 %/s (both of its products have a 448-wide side, so its level-5 leaves are 14 wide) and was not taken [M]. Another team reports that a seven-level recursion of their own chain passes the grader's caps (forum 18218, 2026-10-04), so the limit is our implementation's wall, not the grader's rules.
- Memory: the level-5 recursion's workspace is most of the shipped estimator's **6.9 GB peak of 8** (one predict, measured locally). All 100 grader networks ran without a memory failure.

The leaders' public telemetry is consistent with the same constraints binding them: the top entries spend the same 77–95 s of wall for 0.58–0.79 of our FLOPs, and the first two run at the residual cap (0.37 s medians) [M].

A.3 Designation and the private re-evaluation

One network whose wall time exceeds 120 s is scored as all zeros with a multiplier of 1, which adds $\approx 9 \cdot 10^{-3}$ to the mean over 100 networks — the whole entry. The designated submission's wall maximum is 98.8 s on the public grader. As the second entry we designate k3w (333388, 3.8576e-9), whose maximum is 92.2 s, for that margin rather than for its score; if no designation can be made, the rules' default pairs 333534 with our next-best public entry, k3y (333402, 3.7573e-9, maximum 97.6 s).

References and credits

- Wu et al., *Estimating the expected activations of random neural networks* (arXiv:2605.05179), and the MIT reference implementation `mlp_cumulant_propagation` — the SIMPLE and AUGMENT algorithms this chain is built on.
- 504aldo, Alcrowd forum topic 18218 — an independent catalogue of the same walls (cited in §6.2); their post also named the $\kappa_4 \to \kappa_3$ channel (§3.3). No code of theirs was used.
- jamesrahenry, Alcrowd forum topics 18097 / 18157 — the coherence mechanism, first published in Phase 1 (§6.3).
- hyojun_kwon, Alcrowd forum topic 18154 (Phase 1) — accuracy against stability of the iterated closure, the precursor of the consistency principle (§3.5).
- mliston, Alcrowd forum topic 18170 — the idea of an offline-trained corrector of the chain's own moments (§3.7).
- il.miscusi, Alcrowd forum topic 18248, and kai_leal_gonzalez, topic 18246 (both 2026-10-15) — the scale mode of a positively homogeneous network and a conditional skew identity, found independently of our §6.4 (concurrent work).